DRAGONLANCE

THE TOWERS OF

HIGH SORCERY

A Choose Your Own Adventure Prelude

Book II of the Shadow of the Dragon Queen Solo Campaign | Version 8

Magic chose you before you chose it. Now the three Moons of Magic demand their due. White. Red. Black. Only the Trials will reveal which calls to you -- and whether you survive long enough to answer.

Levels 1-3 | ~25 Hours Solo Play | Version 8 | 80+ Scenes | 3 Robes | 6 Romance Arcs

All 7 Arcane Schools Available | Real Death Mechanic | Connects to Our Campaign

YOUR CHARACTER -- BEFORE YOU BEGIN

USING YOUR OWN CHARACTER SHEET (CPC)

This prelude works with either the Native PC sheet provided on the next page or your own Created Player Character (CPC). If you are using a CPC: • Your CPC must be a Level 1 Wizard with Intelligence 14+ and the Spellcasting feature. • When the prelude references AC 12 (Mage Armor), use your CPC's actual AC. • Spell save DC 13 and +5 spell attack: substitute your own values (8 + prof + INT mod). • Starting spells: use your CPC's actual known spells. The native spell list is a guide. • ADD TO INVENTORY boxes apply to both native and CPC -- add the item to your sheet. • MARK ON YOUR CHARACTER SHEET boxes signal a permanent change -- update your CPC sheet. • TRACK YOUR HP boxes appear after every combat -- update your sheet before continuing. • Level-up boxes will tell you what features, spell slots, and HP your CPC gains.

A NOTE ON TIME

The ~25 hours listed on the cover is a suggestion, not a target. Read slowly. Stay with a scene. Return to a choice. The Trials will wait. This is your story -- take the time it needs.

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Who Are You?

Before Scene 1, answer the following. These shape your story in ways that matter. Write your answers in the space provided or in a separate journal.

Question	Your Answer
Your name:	
Your pronouns (he/she/they/other):	
Your appearance (brief):	
Village of Millhaven -- what did you do there before magic?	
Who in Millhaven do you love most? (NPC you name)	
What was the first magical thing that happened to you?	
Fear more: powerlessness, or what you might do with power?	
Which Moon calls to you? (Solinari=White / Lunitari=Red / Nuitari=Black)	

Starting Character Sheet (Level 1 Wizard)

Stat	Value	Stat	Value	Stat	Value
STR	8 (-1)	DEX	14 (+2)	CON	13 (+1)
INT	16 (+3)	WIS	12 (+1)	CHA	10 (+0)
HP	8	AC	12	Speed	30 ft.
Prof	+2	Init	+2	Spell DC	13

Starting Spell List

FIRE BOLT — Cantrip | Cast: 1 Action | Range: 120 ft.

Ranged spell attack. 1d10 fire damage. Sets flammable objects alight.

MAGE HAND — Cantrip | Cast: 1 Action | Range: 30 ft.

Spectral hand lifts up to 10 lbs. Lasts 1 minute. Can be used to manipulate objects.

MINOR ILLUSION — Cantrip | Cast: 1 Action | Range: 30 ft.

Create a sound or image. Investigation DC 13 to disbelieve image. Lasts 1 minute.

MAGIC MISSILE — 1st Level (2 slots) | Cast: 1 Action | Range: 120 ft.

Three darts, each deals 1d4+1 force damage. Always hits. Each dart targets separately.

SHIELD — 1st Level | Cast: 1 Reaction | Range: Self

+5 AC until start of next turn. Blocks Magic Missile automatically.

DETECT MAGIC — 1st Level (Ritual) | Cast: 1 Action | Range: Self (30 ft. radius)

Sense magic within 30 ft. See auras. Concentration, up to 10 min.

CHOOSE 1 MORE — 1st Level | Cast: Your choice | Range: --

Choose one additional 1st level spell from any school. This is your instinctive magic -- it says something about who you are.

School of Magic (Choose at Level 2 -- Scene 40)

Your arcane school is revealed during the journey to Wayreth. You will choose it at Scene 40, based on how you have been playing. The school does not determine your Robe -- but it will shape which Trial you find most natural and which one nearly destroys you.

Schools: Abjuration | Conjuration | Divination | Enchantment | Evocation | Illusion | Necromancy | Transmutation

Starting Equipment

Item	Notes	✓ Carried
Spellbook	Contains your starting spells. Never lose this.	■
Component Pouch	Material components for all starting spells.	■
Dagger	1d4+2, finesse. Your only melee weapon.	■

Scholar's Pack	Ink, quill, small knife, 10 candles, tinderbox, 10 sheets parchment, personal seal	■
Traveller's Clothes	Appropriate for a village mage heading north.	■
1st Level Spell Slots	2 slots at Level 1. Track: ■ ■	■
Mira's Travel Bundle	Yarrow, bandages, salve. (If Mira travelled with you)	■
Warm Stone / Residue Stone	Trinket. Found after first practice. No mechanical effect.	■
Your Robe	White, Red, or Black. Social effect -- see Robe Outcomes.	■

■ = starting equipment. ■ = conditionally acquired during play. CPC users: your starting equipment may differ -- use this as a reference guide.

YOUR POSSIBLE COMPANIONS & LOVE INTERESTS

ELARA MOSS (she/her) -- *Human, Miller's Daughter, Millhaven-Born*

Appearance	Dark gold hair always coming loose from whatever she tied it in. Ink on her fingers from the ledger books she keeps for her father's mill. Laughs often, loudly, without covering her mouth. The only person in Millhaven who never looked at you like you were strange.
Personality	Warm, practical, deeply rooted. She has never wanted to leave Millhaven and has been honest about this her whole life. She loves you in the uncomplicated way of someone who has known you forever and decided, long ago, that this was the person. She has been waiting for you to notice.
First Met	Scene 7B -- She finds you at the mill the second morning, before Torven arrives. She has brought you bread. She has been crying and stopped and is pretending she has not been.
Romance Arc	Bittersweet from the beginning. She is the person you are leaving. Spark Scene 7B. Flame Scene 11B (the last evening). Oath Scene 21B (the road -- the goodbye that takes too long).
Condition	This romance cannot continue into the main campaign in person -- Elara stays in Millhaven. But she can be a reason you survive, and letters can find you anywhere.

NASHA VREN (she/her) -- *Human, Red Robe Apprentice, Conclave Courier*

Appearance	Bronze skin, cropped dark hair, always slightly overdressed for whatever she is doing. Scars on her left forearm from a Trial that went badly three years ago. Carries a silver coin she flips when she is thinking. Smells of woodsmoke and something electric.
Personality	Irreverent about almost everything except magic, which she takes seriously to the point of reverence. Uses humour as armour and knows it. Extremely good at her job. Has survived things she has not told anyone about. Likes you because you do not bore her, which is rarer than it sounds.
First Met	Scene 22B -- She crosses your path on Day One of the road to Wayreth. She is a Conclave courier heading to the same destination and she looks at Torven, looks at you, and says: 'Another one? He must be having a productive year.'
Romance Arc	Fast and electric, then complicated. She has been to the Tower before. She will tell you things she is not supposed to. Spark Scene 22B if you match her energy. Flame Scene 35B. Oath Scene 62B (the forest's edge, after the Tower).
Condition	Romance does not close through choices but through incompatible robe paths: if you take Black and she is Red, there is friction. If you are both Red -- or White and Red -- it continues into the main campaign.

Eight potential love interests appear across this adventure. Five are unique to this book. Three are characters from Book I who may appear if you played that adventure -- or can be introduced fresh if this is your first. Romance stages: Spark, Flame, Oath. Reaching Oath unlocks an epilogue scene and a bonus in the main campaign.

LYRA ASHFEN (she/her) -- *Human, Fellow Apprentice (Millhaven-born, now bound for Wayreth)*

Appearance	Dark freckled skin, close-cropped natural hair with a streak of white that appeared the first time she cast a spell. Ink-stained fingers. Laughs too loud and does not apologise for it.
Personality	Ambitious, competitive, deeply kind underneath. Has been hiding her magic longer than you. Terrified of the Trials but would die before admitting it. Argues constantly -- it is how she thinks.
First Met	Scene 2 -- You have known her your whole life. She appears in the fields the morning everything changes.
Romance Arc	Slow burn built on years of friendship tipping into something else. Spark at Scene 2 if you tell her the truth about your magic. Flame at Scene 28. Oath at Scene 65 -- only if she survives (she can die in the Trials if you don't help her).
Condition	Lyra cannot be lost except through death in the Trials (Scene 58). Protect her or lose her permanently.

TORVEN ASHFALL (he/him) -- *Half-Elf, Red Robe Mage (travelling escort from the Conclave)*

Appearance	Mid-30s, lean, copper-red hair he ties back carelessly. An actual red robe, worn like a comfortable jacket. A scar across his palm from his own Trials. Smells faintly of woodsmoke and magic.
Personality	Sardonic, experienced, genuinely fond of people who surprise him. Has seen everything and treats it all lightly -- except magic, which he treats with deep respect. Morally flexible in ways that are occasionally alarming.
First Met	Scene 18 -- He arrives at Millhaven as the Conclave's representative to escort you to Wayreth. He is a stranger. He knows your name.
Romance Arc	Flirtatious, then complicated. He knows things about the Trials he is not supposed to tell you. Spark at Scene 18 if you challenge him intellectually. Flame at Scene 35. Oath at Scene 66 -- but he will ask you a question you cannot answer with a lie.
Condition	Torven stays for the whole journey but does not enter the Trials with you. His Oath is decided on the threshold.

THE GUARDIAN OF THE FIFTH DOOR (they/them) -- *Unknown race, Tower Guardian (entity of the Towers of High Sorcery)*

Appearance	Height shifts. Eyes are the colour of the moon that is fullest tonight. Wears armour that has been repaired so many times it is more repair than original. Voice is very quiet, like something heard from a great distance.
Personality	Ancient. Patient. Has watched a thousand Trials and forgotten most of them. Is surprised to find you interesting. Has not been surprised in centuries. Speaks in precise, careful words that mean several things at once.
First Met	Scene 50 -- They appear between the Fourth and Fifth Trial rooms. They are not supposed to. They say: 'You are different from the others. I wanted to see why before you go in.'
Romance Arc	Dark and otherworldly. This romance is not conventional -- it is profound and strange. Spark at Scene 50 if you ask them what they remember. Flame at Scene 60. Oath at Scene 72 -- requires Black or White robe path and completing the Sixth Trial.
Condition	This romance is only available after Scene 48. Cannot be rushed. The Guardian cannot exist outside the Towers -- their Oath is bittersweet by design.

THESSALY BRIGHTWATER (she/her) -- *Half-Elf, War Correspondent (returning from Book I -- or introduced fresh)*

Appearance	If from Book I: you know her already. If new: sharp eyes, copper hair, ink-stained notebook, a silver locket she never opens. Arrived in Millhaven three days ago following rumours of 'unusual events.'
Personality	Witty, curious, emotionally guarded. She has heard rumours that a mage emerged from Millhaven and she followed the story -- then discovered the story was you.
First Met	Scene 12 -- She finds you on the road, two days before Torven arrives. She has been asking about you already.
Romance Arc	If Book I Flame/Oath active: continues from where you left off -- she chose to follow your story here. If fresh: Spark at Scene 12 if you answer her honestly. Flame at Scene 38. Oath at Scene 68.
Condition	If you lied to her twice in Book I, the romance is closed. Otherwise it continues or starts fresh.

COMMANDER SERATH (they/them) -- *Human, Dragon Army Defector (returning from Book I -- or introduced fresh)*

Appearance	If from Book I: their arc continues. If new: they arrive in Millhaven as a supposed merchant, clearly military, clearly hiding something. They are heading to Wayreth, same as you.
Personality	Careful, observant, carrying enormous guilt. If new to you: they are wary and precise. If from Book I: there is history between you that is unfinished.
First Met	Scene 15 -- They appear at the village inn, buying supplies for a journey north. Something about how they carry themselves tells you they are not what they claim.
Romance Arc	Dark and complicated. Spark at Scene 15 if you recognise what they are and say nothing. Flame at Scene 42. Oath at Scene 70 -- requires forgiving them, whether the wound is new or old.
Condition	If you reported Serath in Book I and they were captured: they escaped. They are not angry. This is somehow more unsettling.

ZINNIA QUICKFINGERS (she/her) -- *Kender, Rogue (returning from Book I -- or introduced fresh)*

Appearance	If from Book I: she followed you here. Obviously. If new: she is sitting on your wagon when you leave Millhaven, uninvited, holding your second-best spellbook with open delight.
Personality	Fearless, warm, chaotic. Completely immune to the fear magic that permeates the road to Wayreth. This makes her more valuable than any bodyguard. She does not understand why everyone is so tense.
First Met	Scene 8 -- She is already in your cart. 'I was wondering when you would notice me,' she says. She has been there since before you left the village.
Romance Arc	Joyful escalating into profound. Spark at Scene 8 if you find her delightful rather than alarming. Flame at Scene 36. Oath at Scene 69 -- she tells you the one thing Kender are afraid of, which is being forgotten.
Condition	Zinnia cannot be lost. She is incapable of abandoning someone she has decided to love. Romance only available if you do not tell her to leave more than twice.

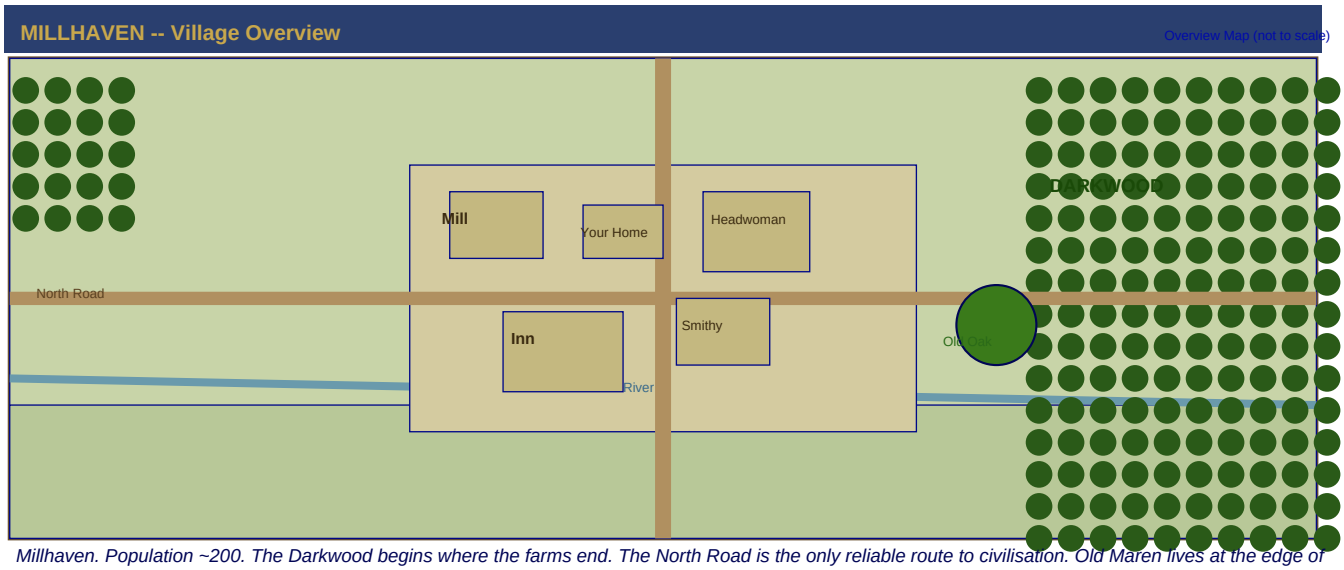
THE THREE MOONS AND YOUR ROBES

SOLINARI WHITE ROBE	LUNITARI RED ROBE	NUITARI BLACK ROBE
Magic in service of good. Order, protection, the preservation of life. White Robes are the most trusted -- and the most constrained. Power used for others. The hardest path because it requires constant denial of self-interest.	Magic in service of balance. Neither good nor evil -- the pivot point. Red Robes walk the knife's edge and call it freedom. Self-determined. Morally sovereign. Power used for the magic itself, and those the mage chooses.	Magic in service of will. Power for power's sake -- not evil necessarily, but unashamed of what it is. Black Robes are the most feared, the most honest about ambition, and the most misunderstood. Power used for the self, and for the dark.
Earns: +WHITE when you protect others at cost to yourself, show mercy, choose truth over advantage, sacrifice power.	Earns: +RED when you act for yourself authentically, maintain balance, refuse both cruelty and self-sacrifice, pursue knowledge for its own sake.	Earns: +BLACK when you choose power over principle, embrace personal ambition, act without apology, take what the magic offers without flinching.

ACT ONE: THE ORDINARY WORLD (LEVEL 1)

Act One Overview

Millhaven is a small farming and fishing village on the banks of a slow river three days north of Vogler. Nothing remarkable has ever happened here. You have lived here your whole life. You are about to ruin that. Scenes 1-20 cover the awakening, the arrival of the Conclave's representative, and your departure.



Millhaven. Population ~200. The Darkwood begins where the farms end. The North Road is the only reliable route to civilisation. Old Maren lives at the edge of the wood.

SCENE 1 -- MILLHAVEN -- THE LAST NORMAL MORNING

Millhaven Village -- Dawn

The village wakes up the way it always does: slowly, with complaining. The miller's dog barks at nothing. Old Petra hangs washing that will be rained on before noon. The smell of bread from the baker's comes across on the wind and someone's chickens are loose again and the river is high this week from the autumn rains.

You have been awake since before the birds. This is how it has been for a week -- sleeping badly, waking to a feeling like something is pressing at the inside of your skull, a pressure that builds and releases and builds again. You have not told anyone. You know what it is. You have known for a long time. Your mother's grandmother, they say, had the gift. It skips generations. Apparently it has decided not to skip yours.

This morning, sitting up in your narrow bed, you reach out -- not physically, but with the thing inside you that has no name yet -- and the candle on your windowsill lights itself.

MAGIC AWAKENS

The flame is blue for a half-second before it settles to yellow. It is very small. It is the most significant thing that has ever happened in this room. Your hands are shaking slightly. You feel extraordinarily awake.

WHITE ROBE	RED ROBE	BLACK ROBE
Order & Good	Balance & Self	Power & Will

Score: ___	Score: ___	Score: ___

ROLL REQUIRED: Arcana (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | Stat: INT -- Roll d20, need 10+ to succeed

SUCCESS (10+): The pressure behind your eyes has been building for nine days -- you now recognise it as spell pressure, the same thing described in the histories as 'arcane saturation.' The candles were not a choice. The magic needed to go somewhere. Understanding this means you can direct it rather than waiting for it to find its own way out. +1 to your first Arcana check in Scene 10.

FAILURE (1-9): The candles lit. You do not know why. You know only that it came from you and that it was not entirely voluntary.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

A) Blow the candle out immediately. No one can know. Not yet. (+1 WHITE, hiding it to protect others) --> *Scene 2*

B) Leave it burning. You have been hiding this for years and you are done hiding. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 2*

C) Touch the flame. See if it burns you. You need to understand what this is. (+1 BLACK) --> *Scene 2*

D) Go wake Lyra. She is the only one you trust with this. (+1 WHITE/+1 RED depending on why) --> *Scene 3*

SCENE 2 -- THE FIELDS

Millhaven, South Field -- Morning

The harvest is in. The fields are brown and quiet. You find yourself here without quite deciding to come -- walking helps, when the pressure builds. The sky is the grey-white of early autumn and the river smells of cold and mud.

You are not alone. Lyra Ashfen is sitting on the stone wall at the field's edge, facing away from the village, hands in her lap. You have known her since you were seven years old. You know the exact set of her shoulders when something is wrong. They are wrong now. She does not turn around when you approach. She says, quietly: 'It happened to you too, didn't it.'

It is not a question. She holds up her right hand. The streak of white in her hair was not there yesterday.

COMPANION JOINS: LYRA ASHFEN

Your oldest friend. Magic awoke in you both on the same morning. She is frightened and trying very hard not to show it. She has been keeping her gift secret for three months longer than you.

Role: Combat support (Utility/Illusion spells). Emotional anchor. Possible love interest.

The thing about the candles is that they were specific. Not ambient magic, not a general warmth -- they moved toward you. The one on the windowsill tilted in the still air and the flame leaned as if listening. You have been trying to decide whether this is beautiful or alarming. Sitting here, in the cold field, watching Lyra's profile, you understand that it does not have to be one or the other. It can be both. It probably has to be both.

Lyra Ashfen: brown eyes, brown hair, a face that is most often slightly serious and lights up when something surprises her. She has ink on her left hand from the histories she has been reading alone. You have known her your whole life. There is something new in how you see her this morning, or you are looking at her differently now that the candles mean something.

A) Sit beside her. Say: 'Yes. Last night.' Tell her everything. (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE SPARK Lyra) --> *Scene 4*

B) Say: 'I'm not frightened.' (You are.) 'Are you?' (+1 RED, turns the question outward) --> *Scene 4*

C) Ask: 'How long?' Her answer is three months. You feel something complicate. (+1 WHITE, +1 BLACK) --> *Scene 4*

D) Say nothing. Sit down. Let the silence be the answer. (+1 RED, Lyra nods once) --> *Scene 4*

SCENE 3 -- THE TRUTH IN THE DARK

Your Home, Millhaven -- Pre-dawn

Lyra is asleep when you knock -- or she was, a moment ago. She answers the door with the alertness of someone who has been lying awake in the dark anyway. She takes one look at your face, steps aside, and puts the kettle on without a word.

You sit across from her at the kitchen table in the grey pre-dawn, and you tell her about the candle. She listens without interrupting. When you finish she is quiet for a moment, then she holds up her own hand. A small bright point appears in her palm -- white-gold, like a captured star -- and then she closes her fist and it is gone. 'Three months,' she says quietly. 'I thought I was going mad.'

ROMANCE MOMENT

The kettle begins to whistle. Neither of you moves to get it. You have known Lyra Ashfen for as long as you have known anything -- and somehow in this particular moment, in the early dark with the kettle whistling and magic revealed between you like a secret made visible, she looks entirely new.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | Stat: WIS -- Roll d20, need 10+ to succeed

SUCCESS (10+): She has been hiding this for three months. Not from cowardice -- you can see in how she held up her hand that she was waiting for you specifically. She did not want to be the only one. She wanted to share the discovery. She is not frightened. She is relieved. ROMANCE SPARK Lyra at Advantage if you respond to the relief rather than the news.

FAILURE (1-9): She has magic. She has had it longer than you. Her emotional state is not clearly readable.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

The specific quality of Lyra listening is that she is entirely present -- no movement, no interjection until you are finished. When you finish, she is quiet for a moment. Then: 'Mine was the window latch.' She shows you her palm -- the small scar from three months ago, the morning she woke to find it open and no wind to explain it. 'I thought I was sleepwalking,' she says. 'I was not.'

A) 'What do we do?' Practical. She needs practical. (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 5*

B) 'Are you afraid?' The real question, the one that matters. (+1 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Lyra if asked with care) --> *Scene 5*

C) 'I'm glad it's you too.' (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE SPARK Lyra) --> *Scene 5*

SCENE 4 -- THE VILLAGE KNOWS

Millhaven, Market Square -- Midday

You did not tell anyone. Lyra did not tell anyone. Millhaven found out anyway, because Millhaven always does. It was probably the miller's dog -- it has been following you around since yesterday with a reverence that is frankly embarrassing for both of you. Or possibly it was when the apples in the market rearranged themselves. You are not entirely certain you did that.

The village's reactions are various. Old Petra thinks you are cursed and says so at volume. The baker's son, who is twelve, thinks you are the best thing to happen to Millhaven since the river festival. The village headwoman -- a practical woman named Dorn who has governed Millhaven for twenty years with minimum drama -- asks you to come to her house this afternoon. Her expression gives nothing away. The NPC you named as someone you love is also reacting. How do they take the news?

Roleplay Moment

Before choosing, take a moment to decide: how does the person you love most in Millhaven react to learning about your magic? Are they afraid? Proud? Do they already know? Whatever you decide becomes true. Write it in your character notes.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Persuasion (CHA, proficiency if trained) (+2) | Stat: CHA -- Roll d20, need 11+ to succeed

SUCCESS (11+): You speak to the most frightened cluster first -- the ones near Petra. You do not argue. You describe what the magic feels like from the inside: pressure, then release, then cold. The specificity settles something in them. They were afraid of the unknown. You just made it slightly less unknown. +1 WHITE, crowd partially calmed.

FAILURE (1-10): Your explanation does not land. The fear has already set. Headwoman Dorn will do better than you with this group.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

What you notice, walking through the village in the afternoon: people who would normally stop to talk do not stop. Not hostilely -- they look away before meeting your eyes, the specific avoidance of people trying not to stare. A child stares anyway, and is pulled back by a parent with the particular grip that means stop that. You are the same person you were yesterday. Millhaven is in the process of deciding whether it can hold both that fact and what you can do.

At supper, your family eats in the way families do when something true has been said and no one knows what to say next. Your mother passes the bread. Your father asks about the weather. The fire is very normal. You are the thing that has changed, not the room, and the room is doing its best to accommodate this with the available tools, which are bread and weather. You eat. You help with the dishes. This is also a form of kindness.

A) Go to Headwoman Dorn immediately. She sent for you and you respect her enough to come. (+1 WHITE, +1 RED) --> *Scene 6*

B) Find the person you love first. Their reaction matters more than the headwoman's. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 7*

C) Go back to your house. You need an hour to think before you speak to anyone. (+1 BLACK) --> *Scene 8*

D) Go find Lyra. You are not doing this alone. (+1 WHITE, Lyra appreciates it) --> *Scene 6*

SCENE 5 -- WHAT HAPPENS IN THE KITCHEN

Lyra's Home, Millhaven

The kitchen at two in the morning has a different quality from the kitchen at any other time. Smaller, somehow. The fire banked to coals. The window showing nothing but darkness and your own reflections, ghostly and close together in the glass. The tea is too strong and both of you drink it anyway -- the ritual of the tea is more important than the tea. You have made it this way since you were children. Lyra wraps her hands around the cup the same way she always has. Everything is very ordinary. Everything is completely changed.

Then Lyra says: 'They'll send for someone from the Conclave. That's what happens. Mages don't stay in villages -- they go to the Towers. You know that.' A silence. 'I've been reading about it. In the histories.' Another silence. 'There are Trials.' She says the last two words with the careful precision of someone who has been sitting with them for three months and has not yet made peace with them.

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A) 'Then we'll pass them.' You say this with more confidence than you feel. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 6*

B) 'Tell me what you found in the histories.' Knowledge is how you deal with fear. (+2 WHITE/BLACK, opens Trial Preview path) --> *Scene 9*

C) 'What if we just... didn't go?' You ask it quietly. Just to name the option. (+1 BLACK) --> *Scene 9*

D) Take her hand across the table. No words. (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE FLAME Lyra if Spark active) --> *Scene 6*

SCENE 6 -- HEADWOMAN DORN

Millhaven, Headwoman's House

Dorn has been headwoman of Millhaven for twenty years. She has handled floods, a cattle plague, two famines, one attempted land-grab by a neighbouring lord, and the year everyone's preserves went off for no discernible reason. She is not frightened by magic. She is, however, practical about it.

She gives you tea. She sits across from you. She looks at you for a long moment with the expression of someone running a complex calculation. Then: 'The Conclave will hear about this within a week. They always do. Someone will come for you, and for Lyra if she has it too, and you will go to the Towers. That is how this works.' She pauses. 'I have sent a message already. Not to speed it up -- to give you time to prepare. Three days before a representative arrives. Use them.'

Three Days

You have three days in Millhaven before Torven Ashfall arrives. These scenes cover those three days. Each one matters. Use this time to deepen relationships, practise magic, and say the things you might not have another chance to say.

Headwoman Dorn has been managing Millhaven for twenty years. You can see it in how she listens -- the still attention of someone who has learned to hear what people are saying around what they actually say. She does not tell you what to do. This is, you understand, respect: she is treating you like someone who already knows what they are going to do and has come here to have it witnessed. She witnesses it. The tea is very good.

A) Use Day 1 to practise magic somewhere private. You need to understand what you can do. (+1 RED, +1 BLACK) --> *Scene 10*

B) Use Day 1 to spend time with the person you love most in Millhaven. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 11*

C) Use Day 1 to research the Towers. Dorn's small library has something. (+1 WHITE, +1 RED) --> *Scene 9*

D) Use Day 1 with Lyra. Work on this together. (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 12*

Between the kitchen at two in the morning and the last conversation, a day passes. It is a day you both know is numbered -- the last before the summons, before the preparations, before the road. You spend it the way people spend days they know are ending: slowly, and with too much attention paid to small things.

SCENE 7 -- THE LAST CONVERSATION

Your Home, Millhaven

You find them at home. Of course you do -- in Millhaven everyone is always somewhere predictable, which is most of what you have loved about it and most of what you have needed to leave. They already know. They knew before you came. This is Millhaven. They are doing something practical with their hands -- the task that is there when you need something to hold -- and when they hear you they set it down.

You have three days. Then you go. You may never come back -- the Towers are not a place people return from unchanged, and the war that is coming may not leave a Millhaven to come back to. They know this too. Neither of you says it.

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Your NPC -- Their Reaction

This is a scene you write. What does the person you love say to you in this moment? What do they give you, or ask of you, or make you promise? Whatever you decide is true. It will matter in the main campaign -- you carry it with you into the Towers.

A) Promise them you will come back. (+1 WHITE, you carry this into the Trials) --> *Scene 6*

B) Tell them you cannot promise that. But you will try. (+1 RED, honest) --> *Scene 6*

C) Tell them what the magic feels like. Give them that piece of you. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 6*

D) Ask them to come with you as far as the road north. (+1 WHITE, one more day together) --> *Scene 6*

That evening you sleep badly. Not from fear -- from the particular restlessness of someone who has made a decision and is waiting for the world to catch up with it.

SCENE 7B -- THE MILL

Millhaven -- Day 2, Morning

Elara finds you the way she always finds you -- by knowing where you will be. The mill is your thinking place, always has been, the sound of the wheel covering over the noise in your head. She is sitting on the sill with a loaf wrapped in cloth and her eyes are red at the edges from something she has already decided to be done with.

She hands you the bread without comment. You eat some of it. She looks at the water. After a while: 'I am not going to ask you not to go. I know better.' A pause. 'I am going to ask you to come back. That is the only thing I want from you.'

COMPANION JOINS: ELARA MOSS

The person from Millhaven who loves you. She will not follow you to Wayreth -- that is not who she is. But she will wait, and write, and remember.

Role: Emotional anchor. Letters from Elara appear at key moments in the Trials as memories. If Oath is reached, she is a reason you survive Trial Two.

ROMANCE MOMENT

She is looking at the water and not at you, which means she is saying the true thing and needs to not see your face while she does it. 'I have been in love with you since we were sixteen,' she says. 'I never said it because you always had somewhere else to be going. This seems like the last moment I will have that is before you become something different, and I did not want it to go past without saying it.'

The thing she hands you is bread, which is practical, and the thing she says is honest, which is more valuable. 'I am not going to ask you not to go. I know what you are. I have known since we were twelve and you kept waking up with the windows open in winter.' She looks at the millstream. 'I just wanted to see you before.' Before, not instead of. She is not asking you to stay. She is asking you to remember.

A) Turn toward her. Say: 'I know. I have known.' The bread is forgotten. The wheel turns. (+1 WHITE, ROMANCE SPARK Elara -- warm and immediate) --> *Scene 11*

B) Tell her honestly: 'I do not know how to ask you to hold onto something I cannot promise to come back from.' She nods. 'I know. I am asking anyway.' (+1 WHITE, +1 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Elara) --> *Scene 11*

C) 'Then I will come back.' Say it like a vow. (+1 WHITE, ROMANCE SPARK Elara, this promise will matter in the Trials) --> *Scene 11*

SCENE 8 -- ZINNIA IN YOUR CART

Millhaven, Your Doorstep -- Dawn, Day 1

You are loading your cart with the things a person takes when they leave a village for possibly the last time -- practical things, a few impractical things, the book your grandmother left you that you have never been able to read. The morning is cold and quiet. The cart is not empty. It contains a Kender.

She is approximately five feet of composed attention, sitting cross-legged atop your spare blankets with a length of interesting-looking rope in her hands. 'I found this on your shelf,' she says of the rope. 'I wasn't sure what it was for. I'm not sure you know either.' She tilts her head. 'I heard someone in this village can do magic. I've been looking for a mage. Are you one?' She says this with the brightness of someone who has just found exactly what they were looking for.

Zinnia Quickfingers is a Kender: four-foot-eight of cheerful fearlessness, large brown eyes, topknot decorated with small found objects, the lightness of someone for whom locks have always been suggestions. She is carrying at least four bags. You will not account for where all of them came from.

COMPANION JOINS: ZINNIA QUICKFINGERS

A Kender who has decided to travel with you. This was not a decision you made. She is immune to fear magic, which will be relevant. She also has your second-best spellbook.

Role: Scout and distraction. Immune to magical fear effects. Will locate things you did not know you needed.

You take the spellbook back. She lets you, which is more impressive than it sounds. She has spent the last ten minutes telling you about the previous mage whose spellbook she borrowed and how it all came out fine in the end, with the confidence of someone with a very flexible definition of fine. You are not sure how she got into your cart. You are increasingly sure she is coming with you.

Zinnia Quickfingers is a Kender: four-foot-eight of cheerful fearlessness, large brown eyes, topknot hair decorated with small found objects, the physical lightness of someone for whom locks have always been suggestions. She is carrying at least four bags. You will not be able to account for where all of them came from.

A) 'Yes. I am. What do you want from a mage?' (+1 RED, direct, ROMANCE SPARK Zinnia possible) --> *Scene 13*

B) Laugh despite yourself. 'Possibly.' (+1 WHITE, +1 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Zinnia) --> *Scene 13*

C) Ask calmly how she got in the cart, as the cart was inside a locked barn. (+1 BLACK, Zinnia delighted) --> *Scene 13*

D) Hand her something from your bag in trade for the rope. (+2 WHITE, Zinnia considers you interesting) --> *Scene 13*

SCENE 9 -- WHAT THE HISTORIES SAY

Millhaven, Headwoman's Library

The histories are old and in varying states of reliability. But the passages on the Towers of High Sorcery are consistent on several points: the Towers are alive, in some sense. The Trials are not a standardised test -- they are different for every mage, tailored to the specific fears and desires and weaknesses of the person taking them. No one who has passed the Trials will describe what they faced. No one who failed them came back to describe anything.

One text, older than the others, has a page someone has returned to many times -- the page is worn, the margins annotated in three different hands over the centuries. The passage: 'The Trial does not ask what you can do. It asks what you will do, and what you will not. It shows you yourself in the dark and waits to see if you flinch.'

You Learn:

The Trials are personalised. Knowing this does not make them less terrifying. It does mean there is no 'correct' answer to study for -- only self-knowledge. +1 to your first Trial roll (if you read this before Scene 48).

ROLL REQUIRED: History (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | Stat: INT -- Roll d20, need 13+ to succeed

SUCCESS (13+): The annotated page about the Trials has three different hands. The oldest is pre-Cataclysm -- a mage who passed the Trials before everything changed. Their note reads: 'The Tower does not test skill. It tests the thing beneath skill.' The middle-period hand underlines this and adds: 'Prepare accordingly.' This is the most useful thing you will read before the Trials. Note it.

FAILURE (1-12): The annotated margins are interesting but obscure. The passage itself is clear: the Trials are personal and cannot be studied for.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

You sit with the books for another hour after you stop reading. The candle gets low. You do not replace it. What stays with you is not the description of the Trials but a detail in the oldest text, added in a different hand: *They knew themselves differently.* Not better. Not worse. Differently, and precisely. The candle goes out. You sit in the dark for a moment and decide that differently is enough.

A) This makes you more confident. You know yourself. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 6*

B) This makes you less confident. You are not certain you want to know what it will show you. (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 6*

C) This makes you determined. Whatever it shows -- you will not flinch. (+1 BLACK) --> *Scene 6*

Armed with what the histories could tell you -- which is incomplete and occasionally contradictory -- you try to do the thing deliberately that you have only done by accident. The magic is patient. It has been waiting.

SCENE 10 -- MAGIC PRACTICE

South Meadow, Millhaven -- Day 1

You go to the south meadow where the river bends and no one goes in autumn. The grass is brown and wet and the sky is wide and grey. You are alone -- except for the magic, which seems to like wide open spaces. It is easier here. Like breathing after being in a small room too long.

You practise for two hours. Some things work immediately -- the fire comes easily, the lights dance when you reach for them. Some things are harder -- the precise control, the stopping as much as the starting. By the end you are tired in a specific new way, like you have been using a muscle you did not know you had.

MAGIC AWAKENS

Late in the second hour something happens that you were not trying to do: all the water droplets on the grass near you lift and hang in the air for exactly three seconds, turning in slow spirals, and then fall back. You feel this in your chest like a struck bell. This is not fire. This is something else. This is the shape of your particular gift beginning to show itself.

What school of magic does this feel most like?

What practice teaches you that the histories didn't: the magic has opinions. Not wishes, not preferences exactly -- more like the way a well-made tool sits in your hand and tells you what it is for. Some things come easily and feel like memory. Some things resist and feel like learning something new. You practice until you have a rough map of both. Torven, when he arrives, will want to know about the second kind. He will call them your school. Right now they feel like your nature.

TRINKET FOUND -- RIVER STONE

When you pack up after practice you find a smooth river stone sitting in the flattened grass where you were working. You did not put it there. It is warm in a way that stones should not be in autumn. The warmth fades over the next hour. TRINKET: Warm Stone. Carries residual magic from your first real practice. No mechanical effect. It is a record of the moment you understood what you are.

TRINKET FOUND -- WARM STONE

When you pack up after practice you find a smooth river stone in the flattened grass where you were working. You did not put it there. It is warm in a way that stones should not be in autumn. The warmth fades over the next hour. TRINKET: Residue Stone. No mechanical effect. A record of the moment you understood what you are.

ADD TO INVENTORY — WARM STONE

A smooth river stone found in the grass after your first real practice. TRINKET: Residue Stone / Warm Stone. No mechanical effect. Native PC and CPC: add to inventory if you choose to keep it. The warmth fades. The fact of it does not.

A) Transmutation -- changing one thing into another, movement, transformation. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 14*

B) Evocation -- raw force and energy, the magic in its purest form. (+1 BLACK) --> *Scene 14*

C) Divination -- seeing, knowing, the information in everything. (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 14*

D) Conjuration -- reaching somewhere else and pulling things through. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 14*

E) Illusion -- making the world look different than it is. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 14*

F) Abjuration -- protection, barriers, making safe. (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 14*

G) Necromancy -- the line between living and dead, the persistence of things. (+1 BLACK) --> *Scene 14*

H) Enchantment -- the magic that touches minds, persuades, changes what people feel. (+1 WHITE/+1 BLACK) --> *Scene 14*

SCENE 11 -- THE PERSON YOU LOVE

Millhaven -- Day 1 Evening

The magic is quiet today -- sitting inside you like a patient animal, not demanding. You take this as a gift. You walk the river path where the willows trail in the water. You eat at the usual table with the usual sounds of the usual village around you. You help without being asked, which is the only time helping is entirely comfortable. You are trying to remember everything in real time, to make a version of this day that will travel.

At the end of the day, sitting together as the light fails, they say something you will carry with you into the Towers. You decide what it is. It is the truest thing they know. It is meant for you.

At the end of the day, sitting together as the light fails, they say something you will carry with you into the Towers. You decide what it is. It is the truest thing they know. It is meant for you.

Write It Down

What does the person you love say to you? One sentence. Write it in the margin or in your notes. In the darkest part of the Trials, you will remember it. If you do -- and if you record it here -- gain Advantage on one Trial check of your choice.

A) You tell them you love them. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 6*

B) You show them one piece of magic -- the most beautiful thing you know how to do. (+1 WHITE, +1 RED) --> *Scene 6*

C) You promise to write to them from the Tower. (+1 WHITE, creates ongoing letter-writing subplot) --> *Scene 6*

SCENE 11B -- THE LAST EVENING

Millhaven -- Day 2, After Dark

CONDITIONAL SCENE

This scene occurs only if Elara Spark is active.

The last evening in Millhaven. Tomorrow Torven arrives and the day after you leave. Elara comes to you not because you arranged it but because there was nowhere else either of you was going to be.

You talk for a long time. About magic, about what you found in the histories, about the village and what you both loved about it and what you both outgrew. At some point the talking becomes something else -- not dramatic, just: the space between you closing in the way it does when two people have been circling something for years and there is finally nothing in the way of it.

ROMANCE MOMENT

She reaches up and touches your face with both hands the way you touch something you are about to lose. Her eyes are open and she is looking at you like she is memorising you. 'Stay,' she says -- not as a request, just as a word she needed to say, knowing you cannot. Then she pulls you close and the candle burns down and the mill wheel turns outside and Millhaven is quiet and this is the last night of the life you knew.

At some point in the evening, one of you says: 'If it changes you too much.' Neither of you finishes the sentence. Neither of you needs to. You sit with the unfinished sentence for a while. Then she says: 'I'll still be able to tell.' She means: whatever the Tower does to you, she will still be able to find you in it. You hope this is true. You choose to believe it is true. That is what the evening is for.

A) Stay until before dawn. Leave without waking her. The kindest cruelty you know how to manage. (ROMANCE FLAME Elara. She will understand. It will still hurt.) --> *Scene 17*

B) Wake her before you leave. Say goodbye properly. It costs both of you. (ROMANCE FLAME Elara. She watches you go from the doorway. You do not look back because you cannot afford to.) --> *Scene 17*

SCENE 12 -- THESSALY ON THE ROAD

North Road out of Millhaven -- Day 2

The north road is straight for the first mile, then curves along the river as though it changed its mind about where it was going. You are on it because the village feels small today -- not badly, just the kind of small that happens when you have been thinking about things bigger than it. She is coming from the other direction, moving with the efficient unhurry of someone who always knows exactly where they are going and has stopped being impressed by it.

She introduces herself: Thessaly Brightwater, correspondent, here because she heard rumours of 'an anomalous magical event in a small village' and anomalous magical events are her business right now. She looks at you with the open assessment of someone who has already decided you are interesting -- just not yet in what way.

She introduces herself: Thessaly Brightwater, correspondent, here because she heard rumours of 'an anomalous magical event in a small village' and anomalous magical events are her business right now. She looks at you with the open assessment of someone who has already decided you are interesting -- just not yet in what way.

COMPANION JOINS: THESSALY BRIGHTWATER

War correspondent following the story of magic in a world where the gods have gone quiet. She is here because of you. This will complicate things in the best possible way.

Role: Intelligence and information network. Knows things about the road to Wayreth. Trusts only honesty.

Thessaly Brightwater is half-elven, which shows in the pointed ears and the quality of attention she brings to things -- that long-focus look of someone for whom time moves slightly differently. Dark hair cut short, ink on her fingers, a coat with too many pockets. She looks like someone for whom the road has become the natural state.

A) Tell her the truth immediately. 'Yes. It was me. Both of us.' (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE SPARK Thessaly) --> *Scene 16*

B) Ask what she knows about the Towers of High Sorcery before you answer anything. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 16*

C) Tell her some of it -- the magic, not the Trials. (+1 WHITE, +1 RED) --> *Scene 16*

D) Ask: 'What do you want to know, and why?' (+1 RED, she appreciates the directness) --> *Scene 16*

SCENE 13 -- THE KENDER SITUATION

Millhaven, Your Home -- Day 1

At some point between yesterday evening and this morning the cart acquired a passenger. You did not invite her. The cart was locked. She is here in the way weather is here -- through no particular malice and no conceivable prevention. Zinnia Quickfingers is, in a technical sense, in your barn. In a practical sense she is already in your kitchen, has found the jar of honey you forgot about behind the flour sack, and is telling you at considerable speed about the last mage she encountered and the fate of his spellbook. The spellbook is fine. She is very clear about this. She shows you. She is holding it.

ROMANCE MOMENT

She looks at you with eyes that are warm and entirely present in a way that makes most people slightly uncomfortable because they are not used to being looked at with no agenda at all. Zinnia likes you. This is simply and completely true. She is not building toward anything. She is just here.

The honey jar is empty by the time the conversation is over. You do not remember eating any of it. She does not remember finishing it either, which is not credible, but she holds to it with the confidence of someone who has maintained more implausible positions successfully. When you ask her directly whether she intends to follow you to the Tower, she says: 'The

Tower of High Sorcery at Wayreth? The one that moves? I've been trying to get there for two years.' She sounds delighted. You have a cart. She has been trying to get there for two years. The logic is unfortunately clear.

A) 'Yes. I think magic is the truest thing I know about myself.' (+1 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Zinnia) --> *Scene 17*

B) 'I think magic is honest. People are complicated.' (+1 WHITE, +1 RED) --> *Scene 17*

C) 'I think the cats are the most interesting detail of that story.' (+2 WHITE, Zinnia delighted) --> *Scene 17*

SCENE 15 -- THE MERCHANT AT THE INN

Millhaven Inn -- Day 2 Evening

There is someone new at the inn. This is unusual enough in Millhaven to be notable. They are sitting at the corner table with a cup of something they have barely touched, and they carry themselves with a military stillness that their travelling clothes cannot quite disguise. They are watching the room. Not like someone people-watching. Like someone doing an assessment.

ROMANCE MOMENT

She looks at you with eyes that are warm and entirely present in a way that makes most people slightly uncomfortable because they are not used to being looked at with no agenda at all. Zinnia likes you. This is simply and completely true. She is not building toward anything. She is just here.

They do not approach you. They drink their drink and watch the room and do not approach you, which might mean they are cautious or might mean they already have what they came for. What you came for, you understand, was whatever information the village had. They have had it for at least an hour. They will leave before morning. Someone, somewhere on the road ahead, knows you are coming.

A) 'Yes. I think magic is the truest thing I know about myself.' (+1 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Zinnia) --> *Scene 17*

B) 'I think magic is honest. People are complicated.' (+1 WHITE, +1 RED) --> *Scene 17*

C) 'I think the cats are the most interesting detail of that story.' (+2 WHITE, Zinnia delighted) --> *Scene 17*

The day proceeds. Word has spread further than you expected -- these things always do in small villages -- and by afternoon there are more strangers in Millhaven than the inn usually sees in a week. Most of them are curious. One of them is something else.

SCENE 15 -- THE MERCHANT AT THE INN

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When you come in, they look at you. There is a moment of recognition that goes one way -- they know who you are, or know something about you -- and then it is covered. They look back at their cup. You have been noticed in a way that was immediately hidden, which is its own kind of notice.

COMPANION JOINS: COMMANDER SERATH (CONDITIONAL)

They are heading north. Same direction as you. They know more than they say. They will travel with you if you do not press them too hard too fast.

Role: Intelligence on Dragon Army movements and road conditions. Skilled protector. Morally complex.

ROLL REQUIRED: Perception (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+2) | Stat: WIS -- Roll d20, need 12+ to succeed

SUCCESS (12+): Exit-checking, wall-to-back seating, the specific way they hold the cup -- Dragon Army field protocols, standard for officers operating in civilian environments. But the scar on their right palm: surgical, not combat. That is from a formal oath-marking -- an officer-level ritual. This person outranked most of the garrison they came from.

FAILURE (1-11): Military bearing, civilian clothes. You cannot confirm the specific affiliation.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

A) Sit at their table. 'You're heading north.' Not a question. (+1 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Serath possible) --> *Scene 19*

B) Ignore them tonight. Watch them instead. (+1 BLACK, gather information first) --> *Scene 20*

C) Ask the innkeeper who they are. (+1 WHITE, practical, +1 information) --> *Scene 20*

D) Leave. Something about them makes you want to be very careful. (+1 WHITE, caution) --> *Scene 17*

SCENE 16B -- THE VILLAGE THAT WAS HERE

North Road -- Day 1 of Travel, Morning

DARK SCENE

This scene contains a depiction of Dragon Army violence and its aftermath. You may read quickly or skip the middle paragraph -- the mechanical outcome is the same. Torven asks you to look at it. He has a reason.

Torven stops the cart at a village crossroads that no longer has a village. The buildings are still there -- mostly. The people are not. The Dragon Army came through four days ago and the signs of what they did are specific and deliberate. This was not a battle. This was a message to the next village about what happens to people who do not comply quickly enough.

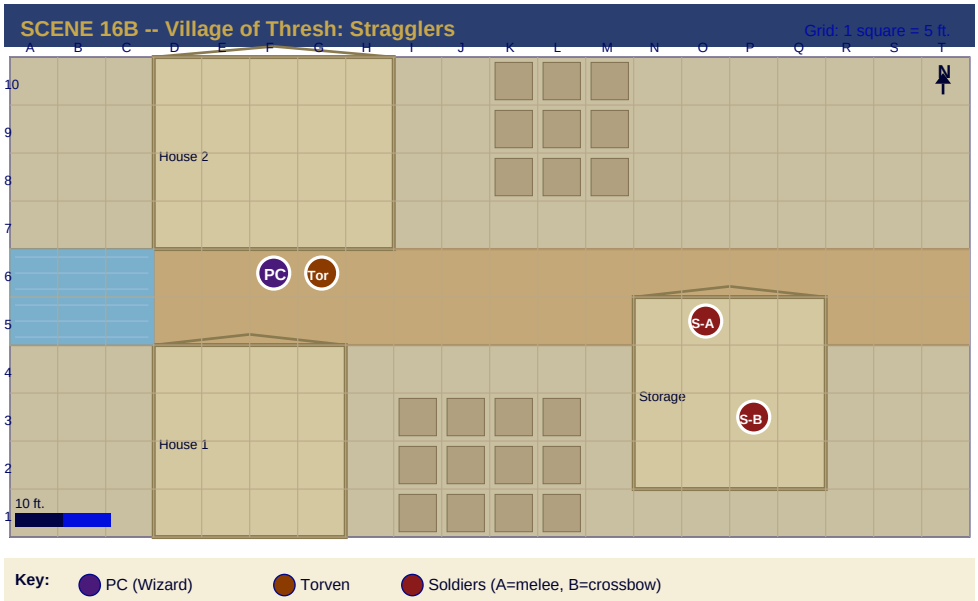
Torven gets down from the horse. He walks into the village square and stops and looks at it for a long time without speaking. You follow him. The smell is bad. A child's shoe on the road. A dog that is still alive and does not know yet that it should not be waiting.

'Every mage who comes to Wayreth passes this road,' Torven says finally. 'I make them all stop here. Because the power you are going to receive -- ' He does not finish the sentence. He does not need to. 'Remember this,' he says. 'When the Trials ask you what your magic is for.'

Robe Reflection

What Torven just showed you will surface in the Trials. In the Mirror Trial (Scene 48), the worst version of yourself may be the one who had this power and used it for the wrong thing. In the Final Question (Scene 58), this village is one possible answer to 'For whom?' Mark this moment. It will be there.

Before you can fully take in what you are seeing, two Dragon Army soldiers emerge from the far building. Stragglers, left behind for reasons you will not ask. They see you. They see the robes. One raises a crossbow.



Soldier B has the crossbow -- he will target you immediately. Fire Bolt him first. Use the building corners for half cover if needed.

COMBAT ENCOUNTER -- VILLAGE STRAGGLERS

Setup: Two Dragon Army soldiers see your group at the edge of the destroyed village. Torven draws his staff but looks to you -- this is your first real fight. Nasha (if present) has already moved to a flanking position. Lyra is behind you. 30 ft. of open ground between you and them.

ENEMIES:

- Human Soldier x2: AC 13 (leather), HP 11 each, Speed 30 ft.
- Soldier A: Longsword +3, 1d8+1 slashing.
- Soldier B: Crossbow +3, range 80/320 ft., 1d8+1 piercing. Will aim for the mage.

YOUR STATS (Level 1): 1

HP 8, AC 12 (or 15 with Mage Armor). Prof +2. Spell attack +5. Spell save DC 13. Fire Bolt cantrip: d20+5, 1d10 fire. Magic Missile: 3 darts auto-hit 1d4+1 each (uses slot). Dagger (emergency): d20+4, 1d4+2 piercing.

Recommended Spells: Fire Bolt to hit the crossbowman first (they will focus you). Magic Missile if you need guaranteed damage on the sword fighter. Stay behind Torven -- let him absorb the melee.

Enemy Tactics: Soldier B shoots at you (the obvious mage). Soldier A charges Torven. If Soldier B is downed first, Soldier A makes a DC 10 WIS save or flees. They are conscripts. They will run if losing.

Escape: Misty Step (if available) or Disengage action + Dash. DC 11 Athletics or one free attack as you go.

Wizard's Edge: You can end most fights before they start. Illusion to split them up. Magic Missile to drop the most dangerous target first. You are fragile. Be clever.

Rewards: 5 XP each. Torven examines the soldiers' insignia. 'Blue Wing, Third Legion. This is not a garrison unit -- they are advance scouts.' He looks at you. 'You did that well.'

Victory: Torven stabilises you (1 HP). The soldiers flee. You wake with the smell of ash in your throat. Proceed with one level of exhaustion and a new understanding of how quickly this goes wrong.

Fallen (0 HP): You are at 0 HP. Torven stabilises you. The soldiers flee or are driven off. Proceed to Scene 17 with 1 HP and one exhaustion level.

HUMAN SOLDIER (CR 1/8)	AC 13 | HP 11 | Speed 30 ft.
Attacks	Longsword +3, 1d8+1 slashing. Or Crossbow +3, 80/320 ft., 1d8+1 piercing.
Special	Morale: Makes DC 10 WIS save when ally is killed or reduced below half HP -- fails = flees.

A) Ask Torven: 'How many times have you made this stop?' He: 'Eleven. I have never stopped needing to.' (+2 WHITE, +1 RED) --> *Scene 22*

B) Stay and bury what can be buried. It costs half a day. Torven does not tell you to hurry. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 22*

C) Say nothing. Stand beside him. Let the silence be what it is. (+1 WHITE, +1 RED -- Torven looks at you sideways. Approves.) --> *Scene 22*

D) Leave quickly. You cannot hold this right now and function. (+1 BLACK -- not wrong. Compartmentalisation is also a survival skill.) --> *Scene 22*

SCENE 17 -- THE NIGHT BEFORE TORVEN ARRIVES

Millhaven -- Day 2 Night

The village has a specific quality tonight. The particular hush of a place that has been talking about something for two days and has temporarily run out of new things to say. The bonfire on the green is smaller than usual. People are still at it, grouped in smaller clusters with more silence between them. Old Petra has been holding court near the well with four increasingly uncomfortable listeners who have discovered that nodding is a form of armour. The sky is very clear. The moons are all visible -- Solinari silver-white, Lunitari its usual ruddy orange, and Nuitari, which most people cannot see, which is the sort of thing you have been noticing more lately.

Lyra finds you after supper. She has been talking to Headwoman Dorn -- who turns out, improbably, to have known a mage once. A Red Robe, twenty years ago, who passed through and left a book. Dorn gave Lyra the book. Lyra gives it to you. 'She said to split it. That it should go to whoever needs it most.' The book is a primer on basic spell theory. It is not much. It is everything.

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A) Give it back to Lyra. She has been at this longer and has more use for it. (+2 WHITE, Lyra speechless) --> *Scene 21*

B) Keep it. You'll share what you learn. (+1 RED, pragmatic) --> *Scene 21*

C) Read it together tonight, now, by lamplight. (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE FLAME Lyra if Spark active) --> *Scene 21*

D) Ask Lyra what she actually wants. She never says. (+1 RED, +1 WHITE, she tells you) --> *Scene 21*

SCENE 18 -- TORVEN ASHFALL ARRIVES

Millhaven, Main Road -- Day 3 Morning

He rides into Millhaven on a bay horse with no particular urgency and the air of someone who has done this many times and finds it agreeable. He wears an actual red robe, practically, like a coat. He is approximately thirty-five and has the manner of someone who decided to stop being impressed by things a long time ago and has found the resulting peace very comfortable.

He finds you without asking directions. He already knows your name. He introduces himself with a handshake rather than any formal Conclave protocol, which tells you something about him. 'Torven Ashfall,' he says. 'I'll be taking you to Wayreth. Both of you, if Lyra is ready.' He looks around the village with the expression of someone doing a rapid calculation. 'Lovely place. You're going to miss it. Most of them do.'

Torven Ashfall is half-elven, perhaps forty in human terms, with a Red Robe worn as naturally as a coat. Laugh lines and careful eyes, the easy authority of someone who has been significant long enough to have stopped thinking about it. He knows exactly how to be warm without being falsely reassuring.

COMPANION JOINS: TORVEN ASHFALL

Red Robe mage, Conclave representative, your escort to Wayreth. He has survived his own Trials. He will not tell you what they were. He will tell you almost everything else.

Role: Magical guidance and protection on the road. Knowledge of the Towers. Possible love interest.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Arcana (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | Stat: INT -- Roll d20, need 13+ to succeed

SUCCESS (13+): You feel the trace magic on him before he reaches the gate -- Red Robe signature, controlled and practised. But there is something underneath it: a secondary resonance that does not match the Red. He was not always a Red Robe candidate. He changed alignment in his Trials. This is useful. He understands doubt from the inside.

FAILURE (1-12): He is a Red Robe mage. The magic signature is controlled and professional.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

The village watches him from a polite distance that would fool no one who grew up in a village. Old Petra is at her window. The baker has found a reason to sweep his step for the third time today. Torven is aware of this in the way of someone who has arrived in a great many small villages and knows exactly what polite distance means. He acknowledges none of it. He introduces himself with a handshake that is neither too formal nor too easy -- the handshake of someone who has calibrated for exactly this situation a hundred times before.

A) Ask him directly: 'What were your Trials like?' (+1 RED, he smiles, says 'Next question') --> *Scene 22*

B) Thank him formally, then ask about the journey. Practical first. (+1 WHITE, +1 RED) --> *Scene 22*

C) 'Most of them miss it -- do some not?' His word choice was precise. (+2 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Torven) --> *Scene 22*

D) Ask: 'Why did you agree to come yourself? The Conclave sends junior representatives for this.' (+1 BLACK, he pauses) --> *Scene 22*

Torven eats before he talks, which you will come to understand is how he approaches most things: the practical before the significant. He notices the figure in the corner the moment he sits down and does not look at them again, which is how you know he has registered them completely.

SCENE 19 -- THE CORNER TABLE

Millhaven Inn

Serath looks at you sitting down without being invited and makes a decision you can see them making. Then: 'Yes. North.' They wrap both hands around the cup. 'There is a road I need to travel before the armies block it.' A silence. They look at you steadily. 'You are the mage. The village has been talking about nothing else for two days.' Not quite a question.

You talk for an hour. They tell you almost nothing personal. They tell you the road north -- which you need -- with the precision of someone who has walked it in a military context and knows every place a patrol would stop. They have information you need. You have -- apparently -- something they needed too, which was proof that the world still has people in it who sit down at stranger's tables.

Commander Serath is in their late thirties, face that reveals almost nothing as a matter of discipline -- square jaw, watchful dark eyes, a scar on the right palm from an oath-marking rather than a fight. Civilian clothes, good quality, deliberately unremarkable. They never sit with their back to a door.

ROMANCE MOMENT

When you stand to leave, Serath says: 'You did not ask what I am running from.' A pause. 'Most people do.' You did not ask because you already knew -- and they know that you knew. Something shifts in their careful stillness. Just slightly. Just enough.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | Stat: WIS -- Roll d20, need 14+ to succeed

SUCCESS (14+): They told you nothing personal but everything else: the road conditions, the patrol schedules, the checkpoint locations. Someone sharing intelligence at that level of detail without personal disclosure is performing a trust test. They want to see if you use what they gave you carefully. If you do, they will tell you more. They are deciding whether you are worth trusting.

FAILURE (1-13): They were informative about the road and uninformative about themselves. The meaning of that combination is not clear.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

What stays afterward is not what they said but how carefully they edited themselves -- what they offered and what they held back, the precise shape of a person deciding in real time how much to trust. You have the sense that the information was a test and that what they are waiting to see is what you do with it.

A) 'It wasn't my question to ask.' (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE SPARK Serath) --> *Scene 21*

B) 'I know what you are. I'm choosing not to make it my problem tonight.' (+1 RED, Serath goes still) --> *Scene 21*

C) 'I'll ask when you're ready to answer.' (+1 WHITE, +1 RED) --> *Scene 21*

SCENE 20 -- WATCHING SERATH

Millhaven -- Day 2 Night

The inn at the crossroads has a low ceiling and a fire that pulls left and the smell of a place that feeds a great many travellers without asking them anything. Half the tables are occupied by people moving with more urgency than they want to explain.

The figure in the corner was there when you arrived and has not moved since in any way that could be called relaxed. Very still in the particular way that is not peace but the achievement of peace-shaped stillness through deliberate effort. Military. Possibly former. Running or scouting -- you will not know which until you make a choice about whether to approach.

You know enough. Dragon Army, former or current. Running or scouting. You will not know which until you choose.

You know enough. Dragon Army, former or current. Running or scouting. You will not know which until you choose.

A) Approach them now. You want to know before Torven arrives. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 19*

B) Wait. If they are dangerous, you will know before the village is at risk. (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 21*

C) Tell Headwoman Dorn. She should know. (+2 WHITE -- but Serath is detained and may not join you) --> *Scene 21*

SCENE 21 -- THE DEPARTURE -- MILLHAVEN FAREWELL

Millhaven, Main Road -- Dawn, Day 3

The village gathers, as villages do, to watch you leave. Some of them do not want to say goodbye and are saying it anyway because they do not know when the next chance will be. The baker's son has made you bread for the road. Old Petra is at the back of the crowd pretending she came to see something else. Headwoman Dorn shakes your hand and holds it a moment longer than a handshake requires.

The person you love is here. Whatever they said to you on Day 1 -- whatever the truest thing was -- you carry it. This is the last scene of your ordinary life. Torven is waiting at the road's edge with the patient quality of someone who has stood at this juncture many times. Lyra is beside you. Your companions are assembled. The road north is grey and cold and long.

The road out of Millhaven is the same road it has always been: three ruts and a drainage ditch and the willow that leans over at the first bend where children have been banging on its trunk for thirty years. You have walked this road ten thousand times. This is the last time you walk it as the person who lives here. You do not look back. Looking back is for people who are not certain, and you are certain. Not unafraid. Certain.

A) Don't look back. You can't afford to look back. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 22*

B) Look back. Let yourself feel it. Carry it properly. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 22*

C) Say something to Lyra before you move. One real thing. (+1 WHITE, +1 HEART if romance active) --> *Scene 22*

LEVEL UP -- YOU ARE NOW LEVEL 2

New Spell Slot(s): You now have 3 first-level spell slots. Choose your Arcane Tradition (school of magic) at Scene 40.

New Feature: Arcane Recovery (Short rest: regain spell slots up to half your wizard level rounded up). Also choose one new 1st level spell to add to your spellbook.

Record this on your character sheet before continuing.

MARK ON YOUR CHARACTER SHEET — LEVEL 2 GAINED

Native PC: now has 3 first-level spell slots. CPC users: • Add your Level 2 HP roll (1d6+CON) to your maximum HP. • Update your spell slots to 3 first-level. • Add Arcane Recovery to your features: short rest to recover slots up to half wizard level. • Write your new chosen 1st-level spell in your spellbook. • Proficiency bonus increases to +2 if you are tracking this separately.

ACT TWO: THE ROAD TO WAYRETH (LEVEL 2)

Act Two Overview

The Forest of Wayreth does not appear on maps. It moves. The Tower of High Sorcery at Wayreth is the last remaining Tower since the others were destroyed or abandoned. The road is five days through increasingly strange territory. Scenes 22-47 cover the road, your companions, THREE combat encounters (at the village, at the checkpoint if things go wrong, and the hunting party specifically tracking you to the forest edge), and the first step into Wayreth.

SCENE 21B -- WHAT YOU LEAVE

Millhaven, Main Road -- Dawn, Day 3 (Elara Flame only)

CONDITIONAL SCENE

This scene occurs only if Elara is at Flame level.

She is at the road. You did not ask her to come. You knew she would be here. Torven and Lyra are ahead. Your bags are packed. Elara is standing at the fork with her arms folded not against the cold but against everything else and she looks at you with the expression of someone who has been awake for most of the night and is not going to pretend otherwise.

She does not cry. She promised herself she would not and she keeps promises. She hands you something -- a small thing, wrapped in cloth. Your grandmother's book, the one you could never read. 'Old Maren says you will need it in the Tower,' she says. 'I do not know how she knew you could not read it. She just smiled.' A pause. 'She does that.'

ROMANCE MOMENT

You hold the wrapped book and she is three feet away and the road is waiting and Torven is not looking at you but he is being very patient. She reaches out and straightens your collar -- an excuse to touch you, very brief, very careful. 'Write to me from the Tower,' she says. 'Even if you cannot tell me anything. Just so I know.' She steps back. She is letting you go. This is the hardest thing she has ever done and she is doing it cleanly.

What she gives you: a small folded piece of cloth with something sewn into it she will not explain. 'For luck,' she says, which means it is not for luck -- it is something she made and does not want to name because naming it makes it too large for a roadside farewell. The road rounds the first bend and Millhaven stops being visible and you carry what she gave you the way you carry everything you are trying to keep.

A) Kiss her one more time. Then walk. Don't look back. (+ROMANCE FLAME Elara -- held at this level; Oath requires finding each other again in the main campaign) --> *Scene 22*

B) Say: 'I will come back different. I want you to know that before you decide to wait.' She: 'I know. I already decided.' (+ROMANCE OATH Elara -- the promise made here carries into the Trials and beyond) --> *Scene 22*

SCENE 22 -- DAY ONE ON THE ROAD

North Road, Day 1 of Travel

The road north is damp and kind to feet this morning. Torven keeps thirty feet ahead -- not distant, just the natural spacing of someone who knows that first days of leaving need room. Millhaven disappears behind the first hill at about the third mile and keeps being gone in the steady way of places you have stopped trying to see from the wrong side of a ridge. The sky is pale. The birdsong is beginning. You are on the road to the Towers of High Sorcery and it looks, unremarkably, like a road.

In the first hour he tells you three things: that the Forest of Wayreth will begin to be visible from the road in two more days, that visible and reachable are different things, and that the forest itself will decide when it lets you in. 'What if it doesn't let us in?' Lyra asks. 'It will,' Torven says. 'You are mages. It knows.' He says this as though it is straightforward. It is not straightforward.

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A) Ask Torven about the Trials. What can he actually tell you? (+1 RED, he tells you what he can legally tell you) --> *Scene 28*

B) Ride in comfortable silence. Watch the road. You need to think. (+1 BLACK) --> *Scene 29*

C) Talk to Lyra. She is handling this morning badly. (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 30*

D) Move to the back of the cart with Zinnia. She is the only one who is actively enjoying this. (+1 WHITE, ROMANCE FLAME Zinnia if Spark active) --> *Scene 31*

By midday the road has found its rhythm. You have been awake since before dawn and your legs know it. Millhaven is half a day behind you. The Wayreth Forest is still somewhere ahead that you can only take on faith. In between: road, and the slow revelation of what it means to be travelling toward something real.

SCENE 22B -- THE COURIER

North Road -- Day 1 of Travel, Midday

She materialises beside the cart the way experienced travellers do -- suddenly, fully formed, as if she was always going to be here. A red robe worn like a very good coat. A silver coin appearing and disappearing across her knuckles with the absent practice of long habit. She looks at Torven with the comfortable familiarity of people who know each other professionally and look at you with the sharper interest of someone encountering a data point they did not expect.

'Another one?' she says to Torven. He: 'Two, actually.' She looks at Lyra. Back to you. 'From the same village?' He: 'Same morning.' She flips the coin and catches it. 'That has not happened in forty years.' She tucks the coin away. 'Nasha Vren. I am heading to Wayreth with dispatches. I will not be polite company -- I work while I travel -- but I will be useful if anyone ambushes you, which is more than most company offers.'

COMPANION JOINS: NASHA VREN

Red Robe Conclave courier. She has been to the Tower and come back. She will tell you things she is not supposed to if you earn it.

Role: Pre-Trial intelligence (she knows things about the Trials she legally cannot share but will hint at if she likes you). Combat support.

ROMANCE MOMENT

She is already reading something as she rides, coin still flickering. But she glances at you twice in the first hour -- quick, assessing, not disinterested. She has a specific way of looking at things she finds worth looking at.

She falls in beside the cart with the ease of someone for whom this is entirely ordinary. She carries a leather cylinder she has not released since she appeared, which means it contains something that matters, which means you are not the only thing she was sent to find. She looks at you with the frank assessment of someone comparing a briefing to the reality. 'Hm,' she says. You cannot tell if it is approval or reservation. Later you will decide it was both.

Nasha Vren: compact and quick, dark hair cut practical, clever eyes with a permanent quality of assessment. Red Robe courier insignia worn on the inside of her collar. She carries a leather cylinder she does not put down. She does not explain what is in it.

A) Ask: 'What do the dispatches say about the Dragon Army on this road?' She looks up. 'That is the right first question.' (+1 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Nasha -- she likes precision) --> *Scene 28*

B) 'What was it like? The Tower.' She goes still for a moment. 'Ask me after you have been.' (+1 WHITE, +1 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Nasha possible) --> *Scene 28*

C) Let her work. Do not interrupt. She notices. (+1 RED -- later she says 'most people cannot leave a silence alone.' This is a compliment from Nasha.) --> *Scene 28*

SCENE 28 -- WHAT TORVEN CAN TELL YOU

North Road, Evening -- Day 1

The afternoon light comes at a low angle through the pines. Torven has been quiet since midday -- the silence of someone sorting through what is permissible from what is true. He does this visibly, like a careful inventory. When he speaks he starts with the things that are sanctioned and accurate, then edges toward things that are true and probably permissible, then -- once -- tells you something that is clearly both true and not what he was authorised to share, in the tone of a man who has decided the authorisation was written by someone who hadn't met you yet.

'Can you die in them?' Lyra asks from the back of the cart. Torven is quiet for a moment. 'You can,' he says. 'Some do. The Conclave accepts this.' Another pause. 'I did not,' he adds, which is somehow both comforting and not.

'Can you die in them?' Lyra asks from the back of the cart. Torven is quiet for a moment. 'You can,' he says. 'Some do. The Conclave accepts this.' Another pause. 'I did not,' he adds, which is somehow both comforting and not.

A) Ask: 'What did you value most, when you went in?' (+1 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Torven if not already active) --> *Scene 32*

B) Ask: 'Do people fail and survive?' He nods. 'Rarely. They come out changed.' (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 32*

C) Ask Lyra -- quietly, so Torven can't hear -- if she is still willing. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 33*

SCENE 30 -- LYRA ON THE ROAD

North Road, Morning -- Day 2

She is walking ahead of the cart, which means she wants space. You walk beside her anyway because that is what fifteen years of friendship looks like -- the understanding that space and alone are not the same thing.

She tells you what she is actually afraid of, which she has not told Torven and would not tell anyone else. It is not dying. It is this: that the Trials will show her something she does not want to know about herself. That the magic will look into her and find something dark, and she will have to decide whether to keep it or give it up. 'What if I'm a Black Robe?' she says. 'I don't think I am. But what if I am and I'm wrong about myself?'

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | Stat: WIS -- Roll d20, need 11+ to succeed

SUCCESS (11+): She is not afraid of the Trials or of dying. She is afraid of discovering that the magic wants something from her that she will not want to give. She is describing a fear of being fundamentally changed by the power, not a fear of failing. These are different fears. The response she needs is not reassurance -- it is recognition. ROMANCE FLAME Lyra if you respond to the actual fear rather than the surface one.

FAILURE (1-10): She is frightened of the Trials. You hear the fear clearly but cannot separate the specific shape of it.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

She walks faster for a while after that. You let her. You understand what she is afraid of, and it is not the Trials exactly. It is the possibility that the Trials will show her something she does not have a name for yet -- something about who she is that she would rather find out slowly, at home, over years, not all at once in a room designed for this. You share this fear. You do not say so. You walk beside her when she slows down again.

A) 'Then you'll be the most thoughtful Black Robe anyone has ever met.' (+2 WHITE, Lyra laughs, ROMANCE FLAME Lyra if Spark active) --> *Scene 34*

B) 'The fact that you're asking means you're not.' (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 34*

C) 'I don't think the colour of your robe is the same as who you are.' (+2 RED, +1 WHITE) --> *Scene 34*

D) Tell her what you are afraid of. Equal the vulnerability. (+2 WHITE, very strong ROMANCE FLAME Lyra) --> *Scene 34*

She walks ahead for the rest of the morning. You let her. Some things need walking distance to become sayable.

SCENE 30B -- WHAT LYRA IS NOT SAYING

North Road -- Morning, Day 2

CONDITIONAL DARK SCENE

This scene occurs if Lyra is still in your party. If she is not present, skip ahead.

Lyra has been quiet since the village. Not the thoughtful quiet she gets when she is working through a problem -- a different quiet, the kind that has walls. She walks ahead of the cart rather than riding, which she does when she does not want to be watched.

When you catch up to her she does not look at you. After a while: 'I practiced on the dog. Back in the village. The one that was waiting.' A pause. 'I used a spell to make it come to me. It did not want to. But I made it come anyway, because I wanted to see if I could.' She says this without inflection. 'The magic made it easy. I did not like how easy it was.'

DARK SCENE

This is Lyra's first real encounter with what her magic can do to a living creature against its will. She is not confessing to cruelty -- she is confessing to the recognition of potential. The fear is not that she did something wrong. The fear is that it did not feel as wrong as it should have.

The silence that follows is not comfortable. It is the silence of two people looking at the same thing and finding it equally difficult to hold. You practiced on the candle. You did not tell her. You are both sitting with the fact that you both noticed the difference between choosing and being chosen, and neither of you is sure yet what to do with the noticing.

A) 'The fact that you are telling me means you know something was off about it.' She nods. Barely. (+2 WHITE, Lyra trust deepens) --> *Scene 35*

B) 'What school do you think it was? The spell?' She blinks. Refocuses. Naming it precisely is how she handles things that frighten her. (+1 WHITE, +1 RED -- you have learned something about how she works) --> *Scene 35*

C) Walk beside her in silence for a while. You do not have the answer. Being present is what you can offer. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 35*

D) 'I would have done the same.' Honest. She finally looks at you. '+1 RED -- complicated. True. Not entirely comforting. But true.') --> *Scene 35*

SCENE 35 -- TORVEN AT THE FIRE

Camp, North Road -- Night, Day 2

The others are asleep. You and Torven sit at the fire for the second watch. He is easy company in the dark -- not performing ease, just actually comfortable with silence and with the particular quality of night-fire conversation where things get said that daylight makes too visible.

He tells you, without prompting: that he failed his first Trial. That he went in as a White Robe candidate and came out a Red Robe because the Trial showed him something about himself that he had not been honest about. 'I valued my own judgment more than any external authority,' he says. 'I thought that was a failing. It turned out to be who I am.' He looks at the fire. 'The Trials don't make you into something. They show you what you already are.'

ROMANCE MOMENT

He looks at you sideways in the firelight. 'You're running calculations on everything I say,' he says. 'Trying to figure out what the Trials will show you.' A beat. 'For what it's worth -- I think you already know. Most people do.' He is looking at you in a way that is different from how a guide looks at a charge.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | Stat: WIS -- Roll d20, need 13+ to succeed

SUCCESS (13+): He told you he failed his first Trial -- but the way he said it was past tense and resolved. He made peace with it. The thing he has NOT made peace with is something that happened between his Trials and right now. There is an unresolved event in his recent history that he has been carrying on this road. If you ask the right question he will tell you. This matters for the Oath track.

FAILURE (1-12): He is being honest about his history. The present-tense weight is not readable.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

A) Tell him what you think it will show you. The real answer. (+2 RED, ROMANCE FLAME Torven if Spark active) --> *Scene 38*

B) 'What makes you think I'm calculating?' 'Because you haven't stopped since we left Millhaven.' (+1 RED, +1 WHITE) --> *Scene 38*

C) 'I know what I value. I'm not sure that's the same as knowing who I am.' (+2 WHITE, thoughtful, Torven nods slowly) --> *Scene 38*

SCENE 35B -- NASHA AT THE FIRE

Camp -- Night, Day 2 (Nasha Spark active)

CONDITIONAL SCENE

This scene occurs if Nasha Spark is active. If not, proceed to Scene 38.

She has finished her dispatches. You can tell because the coin has reappeared -- she only does that when she is thinking rather than working. She sits across the fire from you with her chin in her hand and looks at you with the focused attention she usually gives to documents.

'I want to ask you something and I want you to answer honestly rather than usefully,' she says. 'What are you most afraid the Tower will show you?' She flips the coin. Catches it. 'I ask everyone I escort this. Nobody has ever answered the same way twice.'

ROMANCE MOMENT

She is leaning forward slightly. The firelight catches her eyes and the scar on her forearm and the place where the coin disappears into her palm. She is genuinely interested. Not in your magic or your robes or what you will become -- in the specific shape of what frightens you. People who ask that question are either manipulative or rare. Nasha is not manipulative.

She listens to your answer the way someone listens when they have already formed a hypothesis. After a while: 'Most candidates say one of two things -- either they don't know what to expect, or they've prepared for everything.' She turns the coin over once. 'The first is honest. The second is not. What you said was neither. The Tower will find that interesting.'

A) Tell her the true answer. The one you have not said out loud. (+2 RED, ROMANCE FLAME Nasha -- she holds your gaze after. Then: 'Mine was the same.' She puts the coin away.) --> *Scene 38*

B) 'What was yours?' She considers. Then tells you. It is not what you expected. (+1 WHITE, +1 RED, ROMANCE FLAME Nasha) --> *Scene 38*

C) 'Why do you ask everyone that?' She: 'Because they always come back different. I want to know who they were before.' (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE FLAME Nasha) --> *Scene 38*

SCENE 38 -- THE DRAGON ARMY PATROL

North Road, Midday -- Day 3

Torven holds up a fist and the cart stops. He is very still. Then, quietly: 'Six soldiers. Road ahead. Dragon Army colours -- Blue Wing. They have a checkpoint.' He looks back at you. 'We have a mage, a mage-apprentice, a war correspondent, a Kender, and two other people of uncertain affiliation travelling toward a forest that does not exist on maps. This checkpoint will not go simply.'

If Serath is with you: they move to the front. Quiet. Certain. 'Let me talk first. I know their protocols. If anything goes wrong -- use the magic.' They look at you. 'I have done this before. From the other side. Trust me.' If Serath is not with you: Torven looks at you. 'Thoughts?'

ROLL REQUIRED: Perception (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+2) | Stat: WIS -- Roll d20, need 12+ to succeed

SUCCESS (12+): Before the soldiers see you, you count six -- but there is a seventh figure back from the checkpoint in the tree shadow. An officer, not a soldier. They are not just running a checkpoint. They are looking for something specific. If you choose to go through openly (Option D), open with: 'Conclave business.' The officer will handle it differently than the soldiers would.

FAILURE (1-11): Six soldiers at a checkpoint on the north road. Standard Dragon Army patrol format.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

No one speaks. Torven looks at you. Serath has moved to the front of the cart. Lyra has one hand inside her cloak where her components are. Zinnia is, alarmingly, completely still. The patrol has not seen you yet. Thirty seconds.

A) Let Serath handle it (if present). Trust them. (+1 WHITE, ROMANCE FLAME Serath if Spark active) --> *Scene 39*

B) Use Illusion magic to appear as a merchant convoy. DC 13 Arcana. Succeed = clear through. Fail = combat. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 39*

C) Detour through the forest edge. Longer but avoids the checkpoint entirely. (+1 WHITE, takes extra half-day) --> *Scene 39*

D) Go through openly. You are a Conclave representative's party -- you have standing. (+2 RED, tense but usually works) --> *Scene 39*

E) Ask Zinnia to create a distraction. (She absolutely will. It will definitely work. No one knows what it will be.) (+1 WHITE, +2 chaos) --> *Scene 39*

SCENE 39 -- THROUGH THE CHECKPOINT

North Road Checkpoint

On the other side of the checkpoint the road is astonishingly ordinary. Trees. Ruts. The cart's familiar creak. Your hands are slightly unsteady and you are holding them still with the specific effort of not drawing attention to the fact. Zinnia, if present, is eating something she acquired during the distraction and has not explained, with the serenity of someone who considers this situation entirely normal. Lyra is looking at her palms in the particular way she has when she is reviewing whether she made the right calls. Torven looks at you. 'You handled that well,' he says. He means it exactly as much as it sounds like he means it, which is more than his usual register, and you understand that the checkpoint was also a test he was quietly running.

Torven looks at you after the checkpoint. 'You handled that well,' he says. It lands differently from his usual light delivery. He means it exactly.

Torven looks at you after the checkpoint. 'You handled that well,' he says. It lands differently from his usual light delivery. He means it exactly.

A) Acknowledge it and move on. You have more road ahead. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 40*

B) 'I was frightened. I used it.' (+2 RED, honest, Torven nods approvingly) --> *Scene 40*

C) Check on Lyra first -- she held herself together but you saw her hands shaking. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 40*

SCENE 39B -- THE CHECKPOINT FIGHT

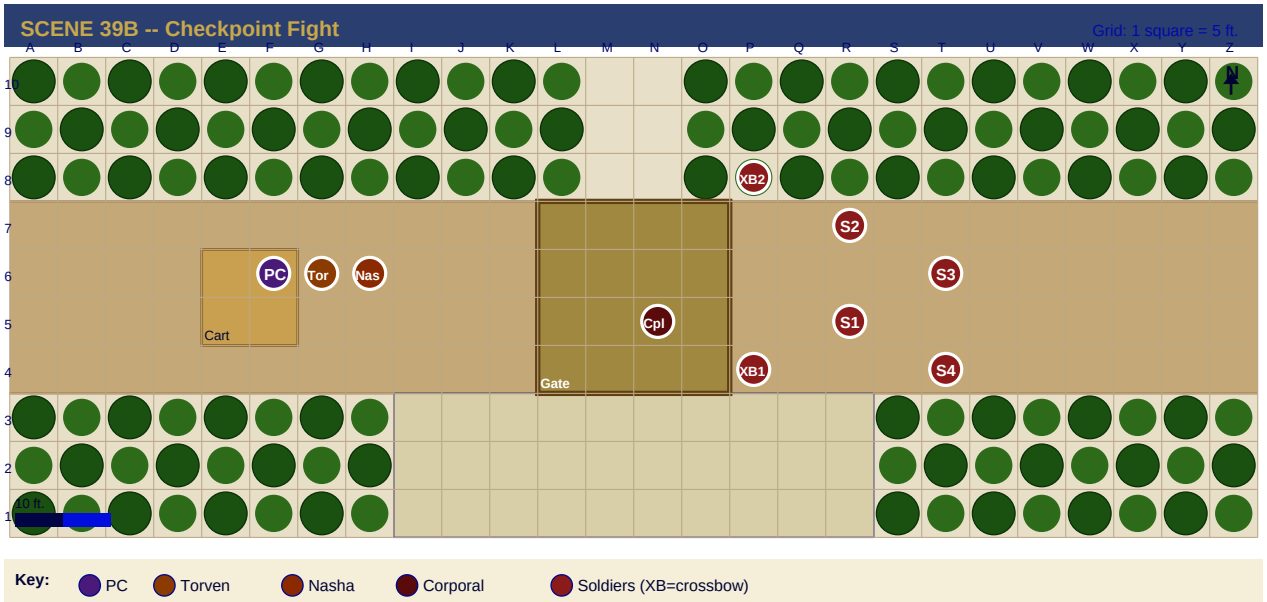
North Road Checkpoint -- if Illusion Failed or Fight Was Chosen

CONDITIONAL SCENE

This scene occurs ONLY if Scene 38 Option B (Illusion) failed the DC 13 Arcana check, or if you chose to fight. If you passed or took another route, skip to Scene 40.

The illusion cracks. A soldier with a torch holds it too close to the cart and the light passes through your conjured merchant and he steps back and shouts. Six soldiers. You have perhaps two seconds before they close.

Torven moves to your left. Nasha (if present) goes right without a word. Lyra pulls Zinnia back. The road is narrow here. The checkpoint is a timber frame that could be knocked down with the cart if the horse will move. You have options. You have two seconds.



The cart needs to break through the timber gate. Thin the numbers fast. Corporal controls his soldiers -- kill him first and the soldiers make morale saves.

COMBAT ENCOUNTER -- CHECKPOINT BREAKDOWN

Setup: Six Dragon Army soldiers, a timber checkpoint frame, and a narrow road. Torven fights. Nasha flanks if present. Your job: thin the numbers fast so the cart can get through the frame.

ENEMIES:

- Human Soldier x4: AC 13, HP 11 each. Longsword +3 1d8+1.
- Crossbow Soldier x2: AC 13, HP 11 each. Crossbow +3 80/320 ft. 1d8+1.
- Corporal (if scouts survived 16B): AC 14, HP 16. Longsword +4 1d8+2. Command: one ally rerolls a missed attack (bonus action).

YOUR STATS (Level 2): 2

HP 14, AC 12 (Mage Armor: 15). Prof +2. Spell attack +5. Spell save DC 13. 3 first-level slots. Arcane Recovery 1/short rest. Cantrips: Fire Bolt d20+5 1d10. Minor Illusion (distract). Key spells: Magic Missile (3 darts, 1d4+1 each, auto-hit), Shield (reaction, +5 AC until your next turn), Detect Magic. Your school feature also active.

Recommended Spells: Scorching Ray targets clustered soldiers (2nd level if you have it by now -- check your school). Otherwise Fire Bolt the Corporal first. Magic Missile for guaranteed hits on whoever is most dangerous. Shield if a crossbow bolt is coming at you.

Enemy Tactics: Two crossbow soldiers target the mage (you). Corporal and two sword soldiers engage Torven. Remaining two spread to flank. Morale breaks if Corporal is killed -- DC 12 WIS save per remaining soldier.

Escape: Misty Step (if available) or Disengage action + Dash. DC 11 Athletics or one free attack as you go.

Wizard's Edge: You can end most fights before they start. Illusion to split them up. Magic Missile to drop the most dangerous target first. You are fragile. Be clever.

Rewards: 20 XP. The cart goes through the frame. On the other side Torven is breathing hard and has a cut on his forearm. He looks at how you fought. Proceeds to Scene 40.

Victory: Cart gets through. You are at 1 HP. Exhaustion level 1. Torven: 'For a mage you took that very personally.' Proceed to Scene 40.

Fallen (0 HP): You are reduced to 0 HP. Torven and Nasha pull you clear while the cart breaks through. You wake on the other side of the checkpoint. 1 HP, two exhaustion levels.

TRACK YOUR HP

After the village fight: update HP and note spell slots used. Native PC Level 1: 8 HP, 2 first-level slots. CPC: record current HP and remaining slots before continuing.

CORPORAL (CR 1/2)

AC 14 | HP 16 | Speed 30 ft.

Attacks	Longsword +4, 1d8+2 slashing.
Special	Tactical Command (bonus action): One ally within 30 ft. rerolls one missed attack.

A) Proceed to Scene 40. --> *Scene 40*

The afternoon light comes at a long angle through the trees. You are still coming down from the checkpoint -- the particular aftermath of controlled adrenaline, which feels like exhaustion mixed with clarity. Torven has been watching you since you got through. Now he pulls the cart to a stop and says: 'One hour. Show me.'

SCENE 40 -- YOUR SCHOOL OF MAGIC REVEALS ITSELF

North Road -- Late Day 3

That evening, Torven watches you practise for an hour. He does not interfere. He makes three small notes in a ledger he carries. At the end, he tells you what the Conclave calls your 'instinctive school' -- the discipline that comes most naturally, that you reach for first, that shows up even when you are not trying.

Choose the school that matches how you have been playing. Each grants a subclass feature that begins to manifest now and will be crucial in the Trials.

CHOOSE YOUR ARCANE TRADITION

Abjuration: Arcane Ward (10 HP temp shield, recharges with Abjuration spells) Conjuration: Minor Conjuration (create small non-magical objects as action) Divination: Portent (roll 2d20 at dawn, replace any roll with portent rolls) Enchantment: Hypnotic Gaze (1 action, charm creature within 5 ft, WIS DC 13) Evocation: Sculpt Spells (protect allies in AoE spells automatically) Illusion: Improved Minor Illusion (sound AND image together with one casting) Necromancy: Grim Harvest (regain HP equal to 2x spell level when you kill with spell) Transmutation: Minor Alchemy (transform small amounts of material for 1 hour)

OPTIONAL ROLL: Arcana (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | Stat: INT -- Roll d20, need 14+ to succeed

SUCCESS (14+): You watch what he writes and can almost read it upside down -- he is mapping your instinctive patterns against school taxonomy. You can see where his pen moves most confidently: one column, consistently. You know your school a half-second before he tells you. When he announces it: 'I know.' He looks up. His expression changes. +1 RED for the autonomy of knowing your own magic.

FAILURE (1-13): He makes notes. He will tell you at the end of the hour.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

He tells you the name of your school and you feel it settle into place like a key in a lock you did not know had a keyhole. Not a surprise -- more a confirmation of something you already knew by feel but lacked the word for. The school is the shape your magic has always been. The school is the shape you have always been. Torven makes one more note. 'This is what the Conclave needs to know,' he says. 'This is also what the Tower will test.' The last day before the forest. You feel, finally, ready -- in the specific way of someone who knows that ready is not the same as unafraid.

A) Abjuration (+1 WHITE -- protection, barriers, defence) --> *Scene 41*

B) Conjuration (+1 RED -- reaching, pulling, creating) --> *Scene 41*

C) Divination (+1 WHITE -- knowing, seeing, preparing) --> *Scene 41*

D) Enchantment (+1 BLACK -- minds, influence, the will) --> *Scene 41*

E) Evocation (+1 RED/+1 BLACK -- power, force, raw magic) --> *Scene 41*

F) Illusion (+1 RED -- appearance, deception, alternate truth) --> *Scene 41*

G) Necromancy (+1 BLACK -- death, persistence, the dark) --> *Scene 41*

H) Transmutation (+1 RED -- change, adaptation, the possible) --> *Scene 41*

SCENE 42 -- SERATH TELLS YOU SOMETHING

Camp -- Night, Day 3

The others are settled. Serath has taken last watch, which they do every night with the quiet thoroughness of someone who does not sleep much anyway. You find them awake and still, watching the road back south. They do not look surprised to see you.

They tell you -- without being asked -- something about what they did before they left the Dragon Army. Not the worst of it. But enough. They tell you in the flat, precise voice that means they are being honest and that being honest about this particular thing costs them something. When they are done they look at you and wait, and the waiting is the only vulnerable thing about them.

ROMANCE MOMENT

Whatever they told you -- it is something only you know now. They have handed you a piece of themselves that could hurt them. They did this not because they trust the world but because they have decided, carefully and against considerable evidence, to trust you specifically.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | Stat: WIS -- Roll d20, need 13+ to succeed

SUCCESS (13+): They are not confessing for absolution or performing remorse. They are offering you information at personal cost because they have decided you are someone who can hold a complicated truth without trying to resolve it. This is the highest form of trust Serath knows how to offer. Do not try to fix it, forgive it, or context it. Just: receive it. ROMANCE FLAME Serath if you respond without judgment.

FAILURE (1-12): They are telling you something painful and doing so without visible emotion. The motivation for telling you is not clear.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

They are giving you information. This is who I was. This is what I did. You have been deciding whether to trust me and I thought you should decide with the full picture. You sit with it. Then you say the true thing, which is not the thing that lets them off but is the thing that actually matters.

A) 'Thank you for telling me.' Simple. It is enough. (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE FLAME Serath if Spark active) --> *Scene 43*

B) Tell them something equivalent in return. Equal the weight. (+2 RED, ROMANCE FLAME Serath) --> *Scene 43*

C) 'What do you want me to do with that?' Not unkind -- genuinely asking. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 43*

SCENE 43B -- THE HUNTERS

Forest Edge -- Day 4, Late Afternoon

The Forest of Wayreth is visible now -- a dark smear against the afternoon sky that is not a natural forest and does not behave like one. You are two hours from its edge when Nasha pulls up short and says, very quietly: 'Do not move. We are being watched.'

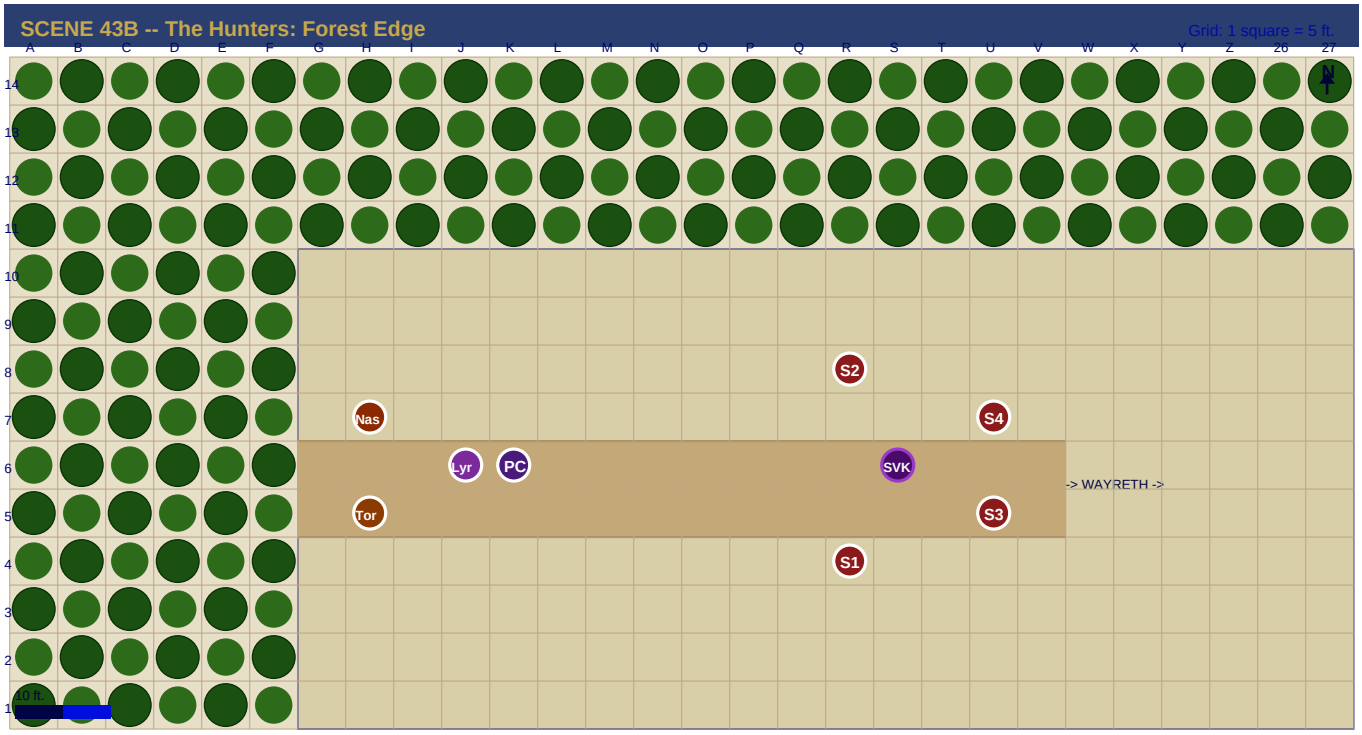
A Dragon Army hunting party. Five soldiers and a Sivak Draconian officer in civilian clothes -- not a patrol, a specialist unit. They have been following your cart's tracks from the checkpoint. They know what you are. The Sivak is looking at you specifically.

Torven says, low: 'The forest is two hours away. It will not let them follow. But we have to reach it.' He looks at you. 'I can hold two of them. Nasha can take one. That leaves three soldiers and the Sivak for you and Lyra and whoever else.' A beat. 'I have

never said that to an apprentice before.'

DARK SCENE

The Sivak is looking at you because it has orders specifically regarding a mage emerging from Millhaven -- the Dragon Army is tracking new magic. This is not a coincidence. Someone higher in the Blue Wing's command understands what you represent and wants you stopped before the Trials.



Key: PC · Lyra · Torven · Sivak Officer · Soldiers

The forest is your objective -- reach it and the soldiers will not follow. The Sivak can FLY (60 ft.) -- it will get to you fast. Do NOT kill it in melee. Suggestion: 'Stand down and report mission failed.'

COMBAT ENCOUNTER -- DRAGON ARMY HUNTING PARTY

Setup: A Sivak Draconian officer and four soldiers in a loose pursuit formation. Open ground between you and the forest edge. Torven and Nasha engage the flanks. You hold the centre with Lyra and fight your way to the treeline.

ENEMIES:

- Human Soldier x4: AC 14 (studded), HP 14 each. Longsword +4 1d8+2.

- Sivak Draconian (Officer): AC 16, HP 48. Greatsword +6 2d6+4. Speed 40 ft., Fly 60 ft.

- Sivak: Shape Steal on melee death (takes killer's appearance, Sivak stats, 1 hour). Hunter's Focus: advantage on attack rolls vs targets that have cast a spell this turn.

- Lyra assists: she casts one spell per round independently (treat as Magic Missile, 3 darts).

YOUR STATS (Level 2): 2

HP 14, AC 12 (Mage Armor: 15). Prof +2. Spell attack +5. Spell save DC 13. 3 first-level slots. Arcane Recovery 1/short rest. Cantrips: Fire Bolt d20+5 1d10. Minor Illusion (distract). Key spells: Magic Missile (3 darts, 1d4+1 each, auto-hit), Shield (reaction, +5 AC until your next turn), Detect Magic. Your school feature also active.

Recommended Spells: Do NOT engage the Sivak in melee -- it will use Shape Steal. Fire Bolt at range. Magic Missile the Sivak if it closes to 30 ft. Misty Step (if your school unlocked it early) to stay at range. Suggestion (if Enchantment school): DC 13 WIS save -- suggest the Sivak 'stand down and report the mission failed.' It works on a fail.

Enemy Tactics: Sivak targets the most visible spellcaster. Soldiers spread to cut off the treeline. Soldiers have Morale (DC 12 WIS when Sivak is downed). If Sivak dies and 2+ soldiers down, remaining soldiers flee.

Escape: Misty Step (if available) or Disengage action + Dash. DC 11 Athletics or one free attack as you go.

Wizard's Edge: You can end most fights before they start. Illusion to split them up. Magic Missile to drop the most dangerous target first. You are fragile. Be clever.

Rewards: 35 XP. You reach the treeline. The forest accepts you. The remaining soldiers stop at its edge and will not enter. The Sivak, if still standing, watches from the road. It does not follow. The forest does not permit what the forest does not permit.

Victory: Torven reaches you before 0 HP becomes fatal. You are stabilised. Lyra half-carries you to the treeline. The forest accepts you anyway -- badly wounded and barely conscious. Proceed to Scene 46 with 1 HP and exhaustion 1.

Fallen (0 HP): You are at 0 HP. An ally stabilises you. Continue with 1 HP and one exhaustion level.

TRACK YOUR HP & SPELL SLOTS

After the hunting party: update all resource trackers. What you carry into the Forest is what you enter the Trials with. Native PC Level 2: 14 HP, 3 first-level slots. CPC: record everything accurately -- the Tower sees you as you are.

SIVAK DRACONIAN (CR 5)

AC 16 | HP 48 | Speed 40 ft. / fly 60 ft.

Attacks	Multiattack: Two Greatsword attacks +6, 2d6+4 slashing.
Special	Shape Steal: On death by melee, assumes killer's appearance (Sivak stats, 1 hour). Hunter's Focus: Advantage on attack rolls vs targets who cast a spell this turn.

A) Proceed to Scene 45 (The Forest Appears) or Scene 46 (Entering the Forest). --> *Scene 45*

SCENE 45 -- THE FOREST APPEARS

North Road -- Morning, Day 4

You crest a low rise and the horizon is wrong. A forest where the farmland should continue -- not a copse, not a windbreak, but a full dark forest occupying the middle distance with the settled weight of something that has always been there, even though you know it was not, even though you walked this road two weeks ago and there was only sky. It has no clean edges. It thickens into itself. The light at its treeline is different from the light twenty feet away from it -- older, denser, as though the trees are keeping something the open air has forgotten.

'The Forest of Wayreth,' he says. 'It found us, which is a good sign. Some groups walk toward it for days and it keeps moving. It means the Tower has accepted that you are coming.' He looks back at you and Lyra. 'Once we enter, the magic changes. Things inside the forest are not quite real in the usual sense. Stay on the path. Do not speak to anything that speaks to you first unless you intend to answer honestly. The forest rewards honesty and punishes performance. Are you ready?'

'The Forest of Wayreth,' he says. 'It found us, which is a good sign. Some groups walk toward it for days and it keeps moving. It means the Tower has accepted that you are coming.' He looks back at you and Lyra. 'Once we enter, the magic changes. Things inside the forest are not quite real in the usual sense. Stay on the path. Do not speak to anything that speaks to you first unless you intend to answer honestly. The forest rewards honesty and punishes performance. Are you ready?'

A) 'Yes.' You mean it. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 46*

B) 'No. But I'm going anyway.' (+2 WHITE, Torven looks at you with something like respect) --> *Scene 46*

C) Look at Lyra. Wait for her. This is a decision you make together. (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE FLAME Lyra if active) --> *Scene 46*

D) Ask: 'What happens to those who are with us -- Zinnia, the others?' Torven: 'The forest permits them if you permit them.' (+1 WHITE) --> *Scene 46*

Torven speaks to the forest before you enter. Not loudly -- conversationally, the way you speak to something that you cannot be certain is listening but whose attention you would prefer to have. He says: 'Three mages. Two new. One returning. We are expected.' The trees do not respond in any way you can detect. You step into them anyway.

SCENE 46 -- ENTERING THE FOREST

Forest of Wayreth -- Threshold

The first step into the forest is like walking through a held breath. The sounds of the road -- the wind, the distant birds, the ordinary world -- cut off completely. The forest is very quiet. Not silent -- there are sounds, but they are below the threshold of language, like hearing music in another room. The path is visible, barely. The trees are enormous and very old.

Torven stops at the threshold. 'I don't go in,' he says. 'This is where my job ends. The Tower will guide you from here.' He looks at you -- at both of you. Something passes across his face that is not quite professional concern. 'Come back,' he says. 'Both of you. I mean that.' He looks at you a moment longer than he looks at Lyra. Then he steps back and the forest's edge closes behind you like a curtain falling.

ROMANCE MOMENT

He does not move until you are out of sight. You cannot see this -- but you feel it, somehow, the way the forest carries impressions. He is standing at the edge. Watching the place where you were.

ROLL REQUIRED: Arcana (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | Stat: INT -- Roll d20, need 14+ to succeed

SUCCESS (14+): The forest is actively cataloguing your magic -- you feel it like a scan, methodical and neutral. You send back: deliberate, honest attention. Not your power level, not your potential robe colour -- just: awareness. The forest acknowledges this and the path ahead clarifies slightly. +1 to your first Trial roll in Scene 48.

FAILURE (1-13): The forest is unreadable. You walk forward and trust the path.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

You look at him. He has been walking candidates to this treeline long enough that the stillness he holds here is something he had to develop. 'Be exactly what you are,' he says. 'I will be here when you come out.' He says it the way someone says a thing they mean completely and have said enough times to know it is not guaranteed.

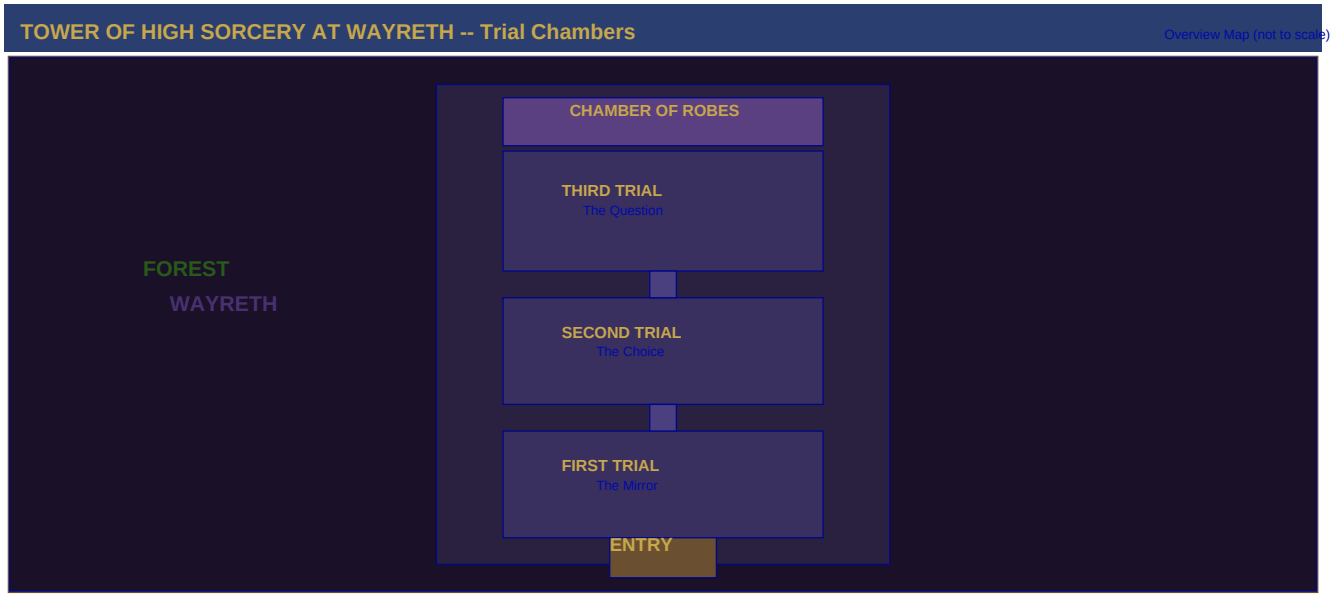
A) Move forward. The path is ahead and the Trials are waiting. (+1 RED) --> *Scene 47*

B) Reach back through the tree line -- just to touch the world outside one more time. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 47*

C) Take Lyra's hand. You don't let go until you reach the Tower. (+2 WHITE, she grips back hard) --> *Scene 47*

SCENE 47 -- THE TOWER APPEARS

Forest of Wayreth -- The Path



The Tower of High Sorcery at Wayreth. The three Trial chambers are sequential -- you pass through each to reach the next. The Chamber of Robes is at the top. The forest surrounds the outside.

The Tower of High Sorcery at Wayreth does not become visible gradually. It is simply there, between one step and the next, as though it was always around the corner you just turned. Black stone. Enormously tall. The windows are lit with lights that are not fire -- not the cold blue-white of moon magic, not the warm orange of flame, something in between that has no name. The door is open. Waiting.

A figure meets you at the entrance: a robed mage, ancient, gender indeterminate beneath the White Robe, whose face holds the compressed patience of someone who has greeted mages at this threshold for a very long time. They speak your name -- both names, yours and Lyra's -- and bow slightly. 'The Trials await,' they say. 'You will proceed separately. This is required. You will see each other after, or you will not. Those are the only two possibilities.'

COMPANION DEPARTS: LYRA ASHFEN (TEMPORARY)

You must face the Trials alone. Lyra takes a different door. You will find each other after -- if you both survive.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Arcana (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | Stat: INT -- Roll d20, need 15+ to succeed

SUCCESS (15+): The lights in the Tower windows are not fire or moonlight -- they are the residual magic of every mage who has ever worked in those rooms. Three centuries of spellcasting absorbed into the stone. The Tower is not alive in the way a person is alive -- it is alive the way memory is alive. It knows you are here. It has known since you crossed into the forest. +2 to your first Trial roll from sheer preparation of understanding what this is.

FAILURE (1-14): The Tower is enormous and ancient. Its lights are not ordinary fire.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

The Tower is real now. Not a description in a history, not a concept -- a specific building with specific dimensions and specific windows that catch the afternoon light and make it older and quieter than light usually is. You stand on the forest path and look at it for a full minute. Lyra stands beside you. Neither of you speaks. There is nothing to say that would not be less than the looking. Inside those walls, the question you have been building toward is already waiting. It knows you are coming.

A) Say what you need to say to Lyra before the doors close. (Write it. Whatever it is. It is said.) (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 48*

B) Tell her you will see her on the other side. Simple. Certain. (+1 RED, +1 WHITE) --> *Scene 48*

C) Embrace her. No words. (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE OATH Lyra if Flame active and she has survived) --> *Scene 48*

LEVEL UP -- YOU ARE NOW LEVEL 3

New Spell Slot(s): 3 first-level spell slots, 2 second-level spell slots. Learn 2 new spells of 1st or 2nd level.

New Feature: Second-level spells now available. Subclass feature fully active. Suggested additions: Misty Step (2nd), Suggestion (2nd), Scorching Ray (2nd), Detect Thoughts (2nd) -- choose two that fit your school.

Record this on your character sheet before continuing.

MARK ON YOUR CHARACTER SHEET — LEVEL 3 GAINED

Native PC: now has 3 first-level + 2 second-level spell slots. CPC users: • Add your Level 3 HP roll (1d6+CON) to your maximum HP. • Update spell slots: 3 first-level, 2 second-level. • Record your Arcane Tradition (school) -- your subclass feature is now fully active. • Learn 2 new spells (any level you can cast). Write them in your spellbook. • Second-level spell slots unlock Misty Step, Suggestion, Scorching Ray, etc.

ACT THREE: THE TRIALS OF HIGH SORCERY (LEVEL 3)

The Trials -- A Warning

The Trials of High Sorcery are real. People die in them. Two Trial Chambers contain direct combat -- bring your full spell loadout. The Trials are not fair fights. They are tests. But they can kill you. The Tower does not want martyrs; it wants mages. But it will not protect you from yourself.

There are three Trials, each harder than the last. Your choices throughout Acts 1 and 2 shaped your Robe score -- but one final moment in Trial Three will confirm or redirect everything.

If you die: turn to the SECOND CHANCE scene for that Trial. You return changed. Changed means: one penalty that persists, and one truth you now know about yourself.

The path between you and the Tower is shorter than it looks and longer than it should be. The Forest of Wayreth does not follow the rules of distance. What matters is not how far you walk but what the forest decides you need to carry in with you. It has been deciding this since you entered.

SCENE 47B -- WHAT THE FOREST SHOWS

Forest of Wayreth -- The Path (just before the Tower)

The path bends and for thirty seconds you can see something in the trees to the left of it. Not a figure -- more like the space a figure would occupy if it were standing very still in filtered light. It is shaped like someone you know. You cannot say who. You look directly at it and it is not there. You look slightly away and it is.

The forest carries impressions, you have already learned this. What the Wayreth Forest carries here, at this bend, is something specific: a memory that is not yours. You feel it the way you feel a draft -- briefly, clearly, and then the path turns and it is gone.

What the memory contains: someone who walked this path before you, who loved someone, who had to make a choice in the Tower that ended that love, and who came out the other side with their robes and without the person. The forest is not showing you this as a warning. It is showing you this as: this is what is possible. Prepare accordingly.

DARK SCENE

The Wayreth Forest holds the emotional residue of every mage who has walked through it. What you just felt was real -- someone's grief, someone's loss, someone who chose the magic over the person they loved. The forest does not judge this choice. It simply remembers it.

What the forest showed the other mage: the shape of a life that chose power over a particular person, precisely once, and what the year after that choice looked like. Not regret. Not horror. Just: the year after. What daily life is like when you carry a particular absence. The forest does not comment on whether the choice was right. It just shows you the texture of it -- the breakfast table with one fewer cup, the other side of the fire, the specific quality of a door that will not open again. You carry this into the Tower. The Tower knows you are carrying it.

A) Keep walking. You have already decided this is worth whatever it costs. (+1 RED, +1 BLACK -- clarity about the price) --> *Scene 47*

B) Stop for a moment. Name the person you would not want to lose. Silently, to yourself. (+2 WHITE -- the forest acknowledges this. The path eases slightly.) --> *Scene 47*

C) Ask Lyra if she felt it too. She did. You walk the rest of the path together. (+2 WHITE -- facing it together) --> *Scene 47*

SCENE 48 -- THE FIRST TRIAL: THE MIRROR

Tower of High Sorcery -- The First Chamber

The room is circular. The floor is black stone, the walls are black stone. In the centre: a mirror. Not a decorative mirror -- a tall oval of polished metal, the surface perfectly still. Your reflection in it is wrong. Not distorted. Wrong. The reflection is you, but at a different age, in different clothing, with a different expression. The reflection is older. It is not afraid. You look at it and it looks back and then it speaks.

It says your name. Then: 'I have everything you want. I know this because I am what you become when you take it. The question the Tower is asking is not whether you want it. Of course you do. The question is: what did you give up to get here?'

The reflection shows you what you become. It is glorious. It is powerful. It is achieved entirely at cost to others. The question is how you respond.

WHITE ROBE	RED ROBE	BLACK ROBE
Order & Good	Balance & Self	Power & Will
Score: ___	**Score: ___**	**Score: ___**

The reflection knows things about you that you have not told it. This should not be possible. This is the Tower. Possible is a different category here. It stands in the mirror with the specific confidence of something that has been waiting for this conversation and is entirely prepared for it, where you are not. The Trial begins the moment you understand that the mirror is not showing you what you might become. It is showing you what you already are, in the moments when you are not looking.

A) Refuse it. 'That is not what I am building toward.' Step forward. (+3 WHITE, Trial 1 passed with honour) --> *Scene 51*

B) Bargain. 'Show me what was given up. Let me decide if the cost was worth it.' (+2 RED, analytical, Trial 1 passed conditionally) --> *Scene 51*

C) Accept the reflection. Acknowledge it without shame. 'Part of me wants this. I will remember that.' (+3 BLACK, Trial 1 passed with self-knowledge) --> *Scene 51*

D) Ask: 'Is this a warning or a prophecy?' (+2 RED, +1 WHITE, the mirror pauses -- no one has asked this before) --> *Scene 51*

YOU HAVE FALLEN

If you tried to destroy the mirror physically, or refused to engage with the reflection at all, the Trial interprets this as inability to face yourself. The room goes dark. You are not dead -- but you are shown the worst version of your fear and have no defences against it.

--> Turn to Scene SC1: Second Chance

You have not looked away yet. This is either wisdom or stubbornness -- possibly both, the way they usually are. The reflection is waiting. The Tower is waiting. The next thing you do will be the first true answer you have given in this place.

SCENE 48B -- WHAT THE MIRROR SHOWS

Tower of High Sorcery -- The First Chamber (continues from Scene 48)

The reflection shows you something specific. Not vague darkness -- not a shadowy worse version of yourself with cruel eyes. Something harder: yourself, exactly as you are, in a moment that has not happened yet, making a choice you recognise.

DARK SCENE

What the mirror shows: you standing over someone who is on the ground. Someone you know. Someone who is alive. You are not helping them up. You are deciding whether to. The magic in your hands is warm and ready and you could heal them easily and what the reflection is showing you is the half-second where you consider whether it is worth it. Whether they are worth it. The expression on your reflected face is not cruel. That is the worst part. It is just -- calculating.

The Trial is not asking whether you would actually do this. It already knows the answer is probably no. It is showing you that the calculating half-second exists in you, and it is waiting to see what you do with that knowledge.

You stand in front of the mirror and look. The reflection looks back. It does not blink first. Neither do you.

A) Step forward. 'That half-second does not define me. What I do after it does.' (+3 WHITE, Trial 1 passed with clarity -- the best possible answer) --> *Scene 51*

B) Step forward. 'I see it. I am not going to pretend I do not.' (+2 RED, +1 WHITE -- honest self-knowledge, Trial 1 passed) --> *Scene 51*

C) Step forward. 'Show me the version where I choose correctly.' The mirror does. Then: 'That is the version I intend to be.' (+2 WHITE, +1 RED -- ambitious, Trial 1 passed) --> *Scene 51*

D) Step back. Reject the premise. 'This is a manipulation, not a truth.' (This is wrong. The Trial knows it is wrong. You pass, but with a penalty: -1 to your Second Trial roll. The thing you refused to look at will be waiting in Trial Two.) --> *Scene 54*

SCENE 48C -- THE REFLECTION ACTS

Tower of High Sorcery -- The First Chamber (Trial Combat)

TRIAL COMBAT

This combat occurs if you chose Option D in Scene 48B (rejected the premise -- 'this is manipulation, not truth'). The Trial disagrees. The mirror makes the reflection manifest. If you chose A, B, or C in Scene 48 and 48B, skip to Scene 50.

The mirror does not accept your refusal. The reflection steps out of it -- not you, exactly: taller, colder, wearing robes that shift between colours, holding power in its hands the way you are still learning to hold. It looks at you with your eyes. It says nothing. It raises one hand.

The Tower is testing whether you can face what you refused to look at. You can run -- the door is behind you -- but that is also an answer the Trial will note.

TRIAL COMBAT -- THE REFLECTED SELF (TRIAL CONSTRUCT)

Setup: A magical construct with your stats and spells, but it hits harder and absorbs damage differently. The room is circular, 40 ft. across, no cover. Just you and it.

ENEMIES:

- Mirror Construct (your reflection): AC 14, HP 30.
- Uses your spells against you: Fire Bolt +5 1d10, Magic Missile (3 darts auto-hit).
- Absorb: The first time it is hit each round, absorbs 3 damage (magical resistance).
- Weakness: it mirrors your tactics with a one-round delay -- it cannot do anything you have not done first.

YOUR STATS (Level 3): 3

HP 18, AC 12 (Mage Armor: 15). Prof +2. Spell attack +5. Spell save DC 13. 3 first-level slots, 2 second-level slots. Fire Bolt d20+5 1d10. Scorching Ray (2nd): three +5 rays, 2d6 fire each. Misty Step (2nd): bonus action teleport 30 ft. Suggestion (2nd): WIS save DC 13 or follow reasonable suggestion. Shield (reaction: +5 AC). Magic Missile (auto-hit). Subclass features fully active.

Recommended Spells: It cannot do what you have not done -- so do something unexpected. Suggestion (WIS DC 13): 'Walk back into the mirror.' On a fail, it does. Fight over. Illusion school: create a false version of yourself as a decoy (Disadvantage on its attacks). Misty Step to stay mobile -- it is slower. Do NOT use Magic Missile exclusively -- it will mirror it perfectly next round.

Enemy Tactics: Mirrors your last action each round. If you used Fire Bolt, it uses Fire Bolt next round. It does not use Shield (it has no reaction). At 15 HP remaining it begins to crack -- shards of mirror across the floor.

Escape: Misty Step (if available) or Disengage action + Dash. DC 11 Athletics or one free attack as you go.

Rewards: 50 XP. The construct shatters. The mirror is empty -- no reflection at all now. A door opens that was not there before. +2 RED (you faced it and won on your own terms). Proceed to Scene 50.

Victory: The construct touches your face and everything goes white. You wake in the Second Chance scene (SC1) having seen exactly what the Trial wanted to show you, whether you wanted to see it or not.

Fallen (0 HP): You are at 0 HP. An ally stabilises you. Continue with 1 HP and one exhaustion level.

A) Fight -- and use something unexpected first. (See tactics above) --> *Scene 50*

B) Run through the door. The Trial notes this. Proceed to SC1 with -1 to your WHITE score. The door behind you closes. (+1 BLACK -- you chose survival over confrontation. The Tower does not disapprove exactly. But it remembers.) --> *Scene SC1*

SCENE 50 -- THE GUARDIAN -- BETWEEN TRIALS

Tower of High Sorcery -- The Corridor

There is a corridor between the first and second Trials. It should take thirty seconds to walk. It takes longer. The light is different here -- warmer, older, like something preserved from before the Cataclysm. And someone is standing in it.

DRAGONLANCE CAMEO -- A NAME THE GUARDIAN DOES NOT SAY

When you ask the Guardian about the mage who changed the Tower most recently, they do not give you a name. They say: 'A young man who changed his robe colour in this room. The only mage in recorded history to do so in the Trials themselves.' A pause. 'He was not kind. He was correct. Those are not always the same thing. He is... significant to what is coming. You will encounter him or his shadow.' The mage is Raistlin Majere, who in his Trials chose Black when he had tested for all three, and who carries the hourglass eyes of someone who sees the dying of all things. He will be one of the most important figures in the War of the Lance. The Tower still carries the shape of what he did here.

They are tall, or perhaps the corridor makes them seem so. Their armour has been repaired many times -- you can see the joins, the different metals, the places where something was destroyed and rebuilt. Their eyes are the colour of the moon that is fullest tonight. They are not threatening. They are -- interested. They look at you with the complete attention of something ancient encountering something unexpected.

'You are different from the others,' they say. Their voice is quiet, as though from a great distance. 'I have watched many thousands come through this corridor. They do not look at the walls.' You have been looking at the walls. They are covered in names -- carved into the stone, thousands of names. The mages who came before. 'I wanted to see you before you went in to the next room,' they say. 'I wanted to ask: what do you understand now that you did not when you entered?'

COMPANION JOINS: THE GUARDIAN OF THE FIFTH DOOR

An ancient being that exists within the Tower. They should not be speaking to you -- they are bound to observe, not intervene. They are breaking their own rules. This is the first time in centuries they have wanted to.

Role: Possible love interest. Source of Tower lore. May assist in Trial Three if Oath is reached.

You ask, because you have been wanting to ask since the corridor started: 'Does everyone feel like this after?' The Guardian considers the question with genuine care. Then: 'They feel themselves. You are feeling yourself. That is not the same as everyone -- but it is not different either.' This is the most reassuring thing they could have said. You are not sure they know this.

A) 'That the power I want and the power I should have are not the same thing.' (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE SPARK Guardian) --> *Scene 54*

B) 'That what I am is more interesting than what I could become.' (+2 RED, ROMANCE SPARK Guardian) --> *Scene 54*

C) 'That I have been afraid of the wrong things.' (+2 BLACK, ROMANCE SPARK Guardian) --> *Scene 54*

D) Ask them: 'What do you remember, from all those thousands?' (+1 WHITE, +1 RED, +1 BLACK, ROMANCE SPARK Guardian) --> *Scene 54*

SCENE 54 -- THE SECOND TRIAL: THE CHOICE

Tower of High Sorcery -- The Second Chamber

The second chamber is not empty. It contains people. Two of them. You recognise them. The first is someone you love -- not Lyra, but the person from Millhaven whose name you wrote at the beginning. They are here, somehow, in this tower they could not have reached. They are in danger. The second person is a stranger -- a child, small and frightened, who is also in danger. The danger is the same for both. You have enough magic for one.

The Trial is not asking who you love more. It already knows who you love more. It is asking something harder: what does love mean when it costs you everything? Do you save the person your heart goes to, or the person your principles demand? There is no right answer. There is only your answer.

ROLL REQUIRED: Arcana (INT, proficiency if trained) (+3) | Stat: INT -- Roll d20, need 15+ to succeed

SUCCESS (15+): The two people in this room are not real in the way that word usually means. They are constructed from your memory -- which means they are exactly as real as your most precise recollection of them. The danger they face is real. The Trial is not asking whether you love one more. It is asking: when love is rationed, what principles remain? Knowing this: the DC 16 Arcana check for the third-path option is available.

FAILURE (1-14): The room contains two people in danger. You have enough magic for one.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

The Trial is not asking who you love more. The Trial is asking: when the question is framed as a choice between two loves, what does it reveal about how you think? Do you accept the framing? Do you look for the door the framing is trying to hide? Do you act on what the framing permits, or on what you actually know to be true? The two people in the room are not enemies of each other. The Trial is.

A) Save the person you love. This is who you are. You live with what that costs. (+3 BLACK, passes Trial with honest self-knowledge) --> *Scene 55*

B) Save the stranger. You cannot save everyone but you can be consistent. (+3 WHITE, passes Trial with sacrifice) --> *Scene 55*

C) Find a third way -- spend everything you have to try to save both, and roll. DC 16 Arcana. (Success: +2 RED, both saved. Failure: turn to SC2.) --> *Scene 55*

D) 'This is not a real choice. This is the Tower testing whether I will abandon my values under pressure. I refuse the premise.' (+3 RED -- but only works if RED score is currently highest) --> *Scene 55*

YOU HAVE FALLEN

You attempted to save both without enough power, and the magic collapsed on itself. You are not dead. But you were not fast enough. One of them is gone. You survived. You will need to decide which one, and you will carry this.

--> Turn to Scene SC2: Second Chance

SCENE 54B -- THE CHOICE UNDER FIRE

Tower of High Sorcery -- The Second Chamber (Trial Combat)

TRIAL COMBAT

This combat occurs automatically in the Second Trial. Whatever choice you made in Scene 54 (who to save), the Trial does not simply let you act -- it makes you earn the action under pressure. Three spectral soldiers materialise between you and whoever you chose.

The moment you make your choice the room shifts. Three figures appear -- spectral, translucent, carrying weapons that are completely real. They move to block you from whoever you chose to save. They do not speak. The Trial is asking whether you will fight for what you chose, or whether choosing was enough.

TRIAL COMBAT -- SPECTRAL GUARDIANS (TRIAL CONSTRUCTS)

Setup: Three spectral soldiers stand between you and who you chose. The person you chose is in danger and the clock is running -- each round they take 5 damage from a secondary threat. You have 4 rounds before they die regardless.

ENEMIES:

- Spectral Soldier x3: AC 12, HP 18 each. Spectral blade +4, 1d8+2 force damage.
- Resistance: half damage from non-magical weapons. Full damage from spells.
- Spread: one engages you, two spread to block your path. They do not retreat.

YOUR STATS (Level 3): 3

HP 18, AC 12 (Mage Armor: 15). Prof +2. Spell attack +5. Spell save DC 13. 3 first-level slots, 2 second-level slots. Fire Bolt d20+5 1d10. Scorching Ray (2nd): three +5 rays, 2d6 fire each. Misty Step (2nd): bonus action teleport 30 ft. Suggestion (2nd): WIS save DC 13 or follow reasonable suggestion. Shield (reaction: +5 AC). Magic Missile (auto-hit). Subclass features fully active.

Recommended Spells: These are CR 1/2 enemies -- they are not here to kill you, they are here to slow you. Scorching Ray to drop one fast (3 rays x 2d6). Misty Step past them -- they cannot follow a teleport. Suggestion: 'You have already succeeded -- stand aside.' DC 13 WIS. On fail, one steps back. Thunderwave (if you have it): pushes all three back 10 ft., clears a path.

Enemy Tactics: They push forward relentlessly. They will not pursue past the person you chose. The goal is not to kill them -- it is to get past them in time.

Rewards: You reach them in time. The person you chose survives. The spectral soldiers dissolve when you touch the person you came for. The Trial chamber goes quiet. +bonus to your dominant robe score. Proceed to Scene 55.

Victory: You took too long. The person you chose falls. You arrive as the secondary threat finishes its work. Proceed to SC2 -- but you did fight. The Trial registers that you tried.

Fallen (0 HP): You are at 0 HP. An ally stabilises you. Continue with 1 HP and one exhaustion level.

A) Fight through -- use the fastest spell available first. --> *Scene 55*

SCENE 55 -- AFTER THE SECOND TRIAL

Tower -- Corridor

The corridor smells of rain. There is no sky here. No windows. No route for weather. The Tower has not seen actual rain in three centuries and the stone is too old to be dreaming of it. You stand in the rain-smell anyway, breathing it in because the Trial left you in a state that requires something specific and real before you can do anything else. The smell is neither of those things. It is precise, and precision is close enough. You breathe until you are only one person again rather than the two versions of yourself the Trial showed you occupying the same body.

ROMANCE MOMENT

They say: 'You are still here. This matters more than it used to.' They say this the way someone says a thing they have been thinking for a long time and have only now found the space to say aloud. Their hand is near yours on the wall -- not touching, but near. In this corridor that smells of impossible rain, something is being offered that has no name yet.

OPTIONAL ROLL: Insight (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+1) | Stat: WIS -- Roll d20, need 13+ to succeed

SUCCESS (13+): They said 'more than it used to' -- which means there was a time when your presence here would not have mattered to them. They have been changing. Across the thousands of Trials they have witnessed, something about yours has been different. They are not supposed to be in this corridor. They broke their own rules to be here. ROMANCE FLAME Guardian at Advantage if you acknowledge this directly.

FAILURE (1-12): They are present when they should not be and they say your survival matters.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

The Guardian is in the corridor. They look at you with the steadiness of something that has witnessed three centuries of this exact state and finds it neither alarming nor surprising. 'You are still here,' they say. Not a statement of fact. A thing that matters to them.

A) Tell them what you chose in the second Trial. Not what you justify -- what you chose. (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE FLAME Guardian if Spark active) --> *Scene 58*

B) Ask: 'Are you allowed to be here?' 'No,' they say. 'I am here anyway.' (+2 RED, ROMANCE FLAME Guardian) --> *Scene 58*

C) Touch the wall beside their hand. (+3 WHITE/RED/BLACK -- depends on context. ROMANCE FLAME Guardian if Spark active) --> *Scene 58*

SCENE 58 -- THE THIRD TRIAL: THE FINAL QUESTION

Tower of High Sorcery -- The Deep Chamber

DRAGONLANCE CAMEO -- PAR-SALIAN, HEAD OF THE WHITE ROBES

The figure in grey robes who conducts the Third Trial is Par-Salian, Head of the Order of White Robes and de facto leader of the Conclave of Wizards. He is one of the most powerful mages in Krynn and one of the few who truly understands what the return of magic means for the world. He has been watching the Trials for sixty years. He almost never conducts a Third Trial personally. He is here because yours was flagged. He does not explain why. If you answer the Final Question well, he says one word: 'Good.' Coming from Par-Salian, this is equivalent to a standing ovation from anyone else. In the main campaign, the Conclave's attention -- and Par-Salian's specifically -- will be a resource and a complication in equal measure.

The third chamber is enormous. The ceiling is so high that it vanishes into a darkness that is not threatening but simply vast. The room is full of light from no visible source -- not warm light, not cold light, the light of pure visibility, which is more uncomfortable than either. You can see everything. There is nothing to see. Just the room, and the question, and the grey-robed figure standing at the far end who has been here, you understand, for as long as there have been mages to ask it.

She says your name. Then: 'I am all right.' And then, after a pause: 'I am different. I think you should know that. I saw something in the second Trial that I am still -- ' She stops. Starts again. 'I chose correctly. I am sure I chose correctly. I just did not know it would feel like this to choose correctly. Nobody tells you that part.'

DARK SCENE

The Trials do not break people -- or not only. Sometimes they show someone who they actually are and the truth is not comfortable. Lyra chose correctly. What the Trial showed her was that correctness can be cold, and she is not entirely sure she likes the version of herself that made the cold choice cleanly. She is still Lyra. She is also someone the Trials have touched. These are both true.

You sit with her. The Hall offers nothing except a bench, water, and the fact that every mage who has come through sat here in this exact state and eventually stood up and went on. She is still Lyra -- Lyra who chose the hard thing and is still learning the shape of what that cost. You say her name. She looks at you. Something releases a small amount of the weight.

The figure does not introduce themselves. They do not explain the Trial or offer reassurance. They ask the question -- the only question, the question the Tower has been building toward since the candles moved in your kitchen in the pre-dawn quiet -- in the tone of someone who has asked it ten thousand times and still listens to each answer as though it is the first. *In the service of what does your magic exist?* Not: what will you do with it. Not: what have you done. In the service of what. The answer is already in you. Say it.

A) 'What colour?' She tells you. You nod. Whatever it is, it is hers. (+2 WHITE, the simplest and most right thing you can say) --> *Scene 62*

B) 'You chose correctly. That is what matters. The feeling will settle.' She: 'How do you know?' You: 'I do not. But I think so.' (+1 WHITE, honest and warm) --> *Scene 62*

C) Sit beside her and do not ask her to explain anything else. Just: be here. Be the person who knew her before the Tower knew her. (+2 WHITE, ROMANCE OATH Lyra if Flame active) --> *Scene 62*

SCENE 62 -- THE ROAD BACK -- AND FORWARD

Forest of Wayreth -- The Path Out

The forest releases you the way it admitted you: without ceremony, simply stepping out of the way. The ordinary world is startlingly loud after the Tower's quiet. Birdsong. Wind. The smell of cold and mud and the real world going about its business without reference to what just happened to you.

Torven is at the forest's edge. He looks at your robes -- both of them -- and something in his face relaxes that has been tense since Millhaven. He does not say anything for a moment. Then: 'Good.' It contains a great deal. Your other companions are here: Zinnia, who runs at you with the complete abandon of someone who does not have the word 'composure' in their vocabulary; and whoever else made the journey.

The Guardian

If you reached Flame or Oath level with the Guardian: they appear at the forest's edge, just inside the tree line. They cannot come further. They look at you. Turn to Scene 72 for your Guardian epilogue.

ROLL REQUIRED: Perception (WIS, proficiency if trained) (+2) | Stat: WIS -- Roll d20, need 13+ to succeed

SUCCESS (13+): The smoke over the southern treeline is wrong -- too wide for a campfire, too dark for controlled burning, moving in a pattern that means multiple sources coordinated. The Dragon Army is burning something large and doing it systematically. Vogler is in their direct path. You have less time than Torven calculates. Tell him.

FAILURE (1-12): The sky south looks like autumn sky. Nothing specific registers.

Add your proficiency (+2) if you are proficient in this skill. No dice? Flip a coin: Heads = success.

You carry three things out of the Tower that you did not carry in: the robe, the Trials, and a quality of attention to the world that was not there before. The magic feels different now -- not stronger, necessarily, but more deliberate, as if it has learned what you are and settled into the shape of it. The ordinary world is outside the tree line. The ordinary world is no longer a place you fully live in. This is not a loss. It is a renegotiation.

A) Head south. Vogler is three days away and the Dragon Army is moving. (+1 RED, practical) --> *Scene 63*

B) Take a moment. Just one. You have earned one moment. (+2 WHITE) --> *Scene 63*

C) Go to Torven first. (+1 RED, +romance continuation if applicable) --> *Scene 63*

The forest releases you without ceremony. One step you are inside it -- that green, patient, watching dark -- and then you are not. The ordinary sky is enormous after the Tower. The road south is visible. Torven is somewhere ahead. And at the treeline, standing very still, is someone you were not expecting.

SCENE 62B -- THE FOREST'S EDGE -- NASHA

Forest of Wayreth -- The Path Out (Nasha Flame active)

CONDITIONAL SCENE

This scene occurs if Nasha is at Flame level or above.

She is waiting at the treeline. Not Torven's spot -- further along, where the forest thins into a small clearing before the road begins again. She has been here a while. The coin is still.

She looks at your robes. Takes them in. Then she looks at your face, which tells her something different and more important than the colour of the robes. She says: 'You came back.' Not surprised. Relieved. She does not usually let herself be relieved where people can see it. She is letting you see it.

ROMANCE MOMENT

She crosses to you and her hand comes up to your jaw -- her palm warm, the callus from the coin rough against your skin -- and she looks at you with the complete focused attention she gives to things she has decided matter. 'I am going to tell you something I have not told anyone,' she says. 'My Trial showed me a version of myself that did not care about anything. Not nihilism -- just: nothing left to care about. That frightened me more than any amount of darkness.' She is still looking at you. 'You are one of the things that makes that version of me less possible. I thought you should know that.'

She fell in beside the cart the first day with the ease of someone for whom falling in beside things is a skill, and she has been with you since. She hands back the coin. Not the one she carries -- her coin, the worn one. She presses it into your hand and closes your fingers around it without explaining why and without asking for acknowledgment. Then she steps back. The road south is there. You are standing at the edge of the ordinary world with a robe on your back and her coin in your hand and everything ahead of you still to find out.

A) 'So are you. For me.' Her breath catches. Then she kisses you -- direct and deliberate, tasting of woodsmoke and road dust. When she pulls back the coin is in your hand. She put it there. 'Something to remember me by,' she says, 'when you are famous.' (+ROMANCE OATH Nasha, vivid fade to black follows if you choose) --> *Scene 63*

B) Take her hand. No words. Start walking. She falls into step with you and her shoulder finds yours and neither of you lets go of the other's hand until you reach camp. That night the watch is not as lonely as it has been. (+ROMANCE OATH Nasha) --> *Scene 63*

SECOND CHANCE SCENES

SCENE SC1 -- SECOND CHANCE -- TRIAL ONE

You wake on the floor of the first chamber. The mirror is gone. The room is dim. Your body is intact but something feels different -- an absence where something was before, like a room with a piece of furniture removed. The Tower did not kill you. It showed you everything you were afraid to look at, all at once, with no preparation, and let you wake up in the aftermath.

Penalty: You have Disadvantage on Insight checks until you complete a Long Rest after the Trials. The thing you refused to face has left a blind spot. Gain: You know now that you can survive the worst thing you were afraid of. This is worth something.

You are not dead. But you are not fully conscious either -- you are in the space the Tower uses for people who need to come back a different way. It is dark and it has weight, and somewhere in the dark something is still moving.

TRIAL COMBAT -- THE DARK BETWEEN (SECOND CHANCE COMBAT)

Setup: You are fighting your way back to consciousness. The opponent is not a creature -- it is a manifestation of the thing the Trial showed you. Abstract. Personal. Real enough to hurt.

ENEMIES:

- The Unresolved Thing: AC 10, HP 20. It hits as your own worst fear -- takes the form of whatever the Trial showed you. Damage: 1d8 psychic per hit.

- It weakens when you name it accurately -- each time you identify what it actually is, it takes an extra 1d6 damage.

YOUR STATS (Level 3): 3

HP 18, AC 12 (Mage Armor: 15). Prof +2. Spell attack +5. Spell save DC 13. 3 first-level slots, 2 second-level slots. Fire Bolt d20+5 1d10. Scorching Ray (2nd): three +5 rays, 2d6 fire each. Misty Step (2nd): bonus action teleport 30 ft. Suggestion (2nd): WIS save DC 13 or follow reasonable suggestion. Shield (reaction: +5 AC). Magic Missile (auto-hit). Subclass features fully active.

Recommended Spells: You have only cantrips here -- no spell slots. Fire Bolt is your primary option. Toll the Dead (if Necromancy school) hits for 1d12. Name it: as a bonus action, describe what the Trial showed you. On a DC 10 INT check, the naming deals 1d6 extra damage. You only need to bring it to 0 HP, not defeat it beautifully.

Enemy Tactics: It pursues relentlessly but cannot move faster than you. It mirrors the pace of your fear -- if you panic (take more than 10 HP in one round), it speeds up. Steady, deliberate spellcasting holds it to a manageable pace.

Rewards: It dissolves. You wake in the Trial corridor with 1 HP and the penalty listed in the Second Chance scene. But you came back on your own terms. Mark +1 to whichever robe score matches how you named the thing.

Victory: It overwhelms you. You wake in the corridor with 1 HP, the standard Second Chance penalty, and -1 to your highest robe score. You came back -- but not clean.

Fallen (0 HP): You are at 0 HP. An ally stabilises you. Continue with 1 HP and one exhaustion level.

A) Stand up. Continue to Trial Two. The door is still open. (-1 to your highest Robe score, then proceed to Scene 54) --> *Scene 54*

SCENE SC2 -- SECOND CHANCE -- TRIAL TWO

You wake in the corridor between Trials. The Guardian is there. They are not surprised. They look at you with the expression of something that has seen this before and does not find it less significant for the repetition. 'You tried to save everyone,' they say. 'This is not a flaw. It was not enough. Those are both true at once.'

Penalty: The person from Millhaven or the stranger (your choice which) is gone from the Trial. This does not affect the real world -- but you carry the weight as though it does. You have Disadvantage on one social skill of your choice for this session. Gain: The Guardian looks at you with something deeper than interest. ROMANCE FLAME Guardian activates automatically if

Spark was active.

The corridor between the Trials is the same corridor. The rain-smell is the same rain-smell. You are in the same body, in roughly the same condition, but the Trial is not the same Trial -- you have used your chance and been returned and the Second Trial will know this. The Tower does not penalise dying. It penalises what dying revealed about your limits. Go into the Second Trial knowing yours. This is the advantage. Use it.

The Guardian waits while you reorient. They have done this many times -- waited in this corridor for mages returning from what should have killed them, watching the specific process of someone reassembling themselves from what the Trial showed. They do not hurry you. They do not speak. When you are ready -- when you are as ready as you will be -- they simply turn toward the second door. The corridor is the same corridor. The rain-smell is the same. The door is ahead of you. You died in the first Trial and came back with something the living do not get to know: you know, approximately, where your edges are. Use that.

A) Continue. You are still a mage. The Third Trial is still ahead. (Proceed to Scene 58) --> *Scene 58*

SCENE SC3 -- THE UNCHOSEN -- FAILING THE FINAL TRIAL

The Tower releases you without robes. This is rare. It is not a death sentence -- the Conclave does not harm those it judges unready. It simply sends them back to the world to become ready. You may attempt the Trials again in one year. The mage who told you this has the careful tone of someone delivering news that requires precision.

You are still a mage. The magic is still in you. Your Level 3 features are intact. You simply bear no robe and carry no Conclave sanction. In the main campaign this creates a unique situation: you are powerful and unaffiliated. Some doors are closed. Others -- unexpectedly -- open.

Unchosen Path

This is a valid ending. The main campaign has specific scenes for an Unchosen mage. You are not broken -- you are unfinished. That is different. Gain the trait: Wild Magic (once per session, when you cast a spell, roll a d20. On a 1, the DM chooses the Wild Magic table effect. On a 20, double the spell's effect.)

What the Conclave does not tell the unchosen -- what the records show only if you know where to look -- is that the majority of the most significant mages in Krynnish history emerged from the Tower without robes. Not because they failed. Because they told the truth about something the Tower was not expecting, and the Tower, which has heard ten thousand answers, was not prepared to categorise it. The Wild Magic you carry is not a consolation prize. It is what happens when a person is too genuinely themselves to fit into the three categories the Conclave offers. This is, depending on how you hold it, either a problem or the most interesting thing about you.

A) Accept this. Go to the reunion at Scene 61. Lyra will be there. (+2 RED, you have your own path) --> *Scene 61*

ROBE OUTCOMES

MARK ON YOUR SHEET -- PERMANENT CHANGE

You have claimed your robe and passed the Trials of High Sorcery. CPC users -- record these changes permanently: * Mage of the [White / Red / Black] Robes (Conclave-recognised) * Your robe campaign feature -- see Robe Outcomes below * You are subject to and protected by the Conclave three moons law * Social effect: NPC reactions are now shaped by your robe colour

THE WHITE ROBE

Solinari's Light -- Order in Service of Good

The white robe is heavier than it looks. It is not the robe of the uncomplicated. It is the robe of those who have seen what power can do and chosen, consciously and repeatedly, to put it in service of others. You are not naive -- you passed the same Trials everyone does. You simply came out the other side with the same answer you went in with. The Conclave notes this. It is rarer than it sounds.

Title Granted

Mage of the White Robes, sanctioned by the Conclave of High Sorcery.

Campaign Feature (carry into main adventure)

Light of Solinari (1/day): When you cast a healing or protective spell, it heals or protects for maximum effect (no dice roll needed).

Your Road to Vogler:

You ride toward Vogler carrying the weight of what magic means when it is given rather than kept. The Dragon Army ahead of you has Black Robe support. You are what stands on the other side of that equation. Start the main campaign with advantage on Arcana checks and the trait: Trusted (Solamnic knights recognise your robe and extend immediate cautious trust).

THE RED ROBE

Lunitari's Balance -- Power in Service of the Self

The red robe is the most honest robe. It does not pretend to virtue it has not earned, and it does not pretend to darkness it does not feel. You are neither weapon nor tool. You are a mage -- sovereign, accountable to yourself, walking the knife's edge because the knife's edge is the most interesting place to walk. The Conclave respects Red Robes for the same reason they find them difficult: you answer only to yourselves.

Title Granted

Mage of the Red Robes, independent practitioner, Conclave-sanctioned.

Campaign Feature (carry into main adventure)

Lunitari's Flexibility (2/day): After casting a spell, you may choose to apply a secondary effect: the spell's damage type changes to one of your choice, or its duration doubles. Your call. Always.

Your Road to Vogler:

You ride toward Vogler as your own person in a world that wants everyone to belong to a side. Both sides will want you. You will decide who, if anyone, gets what they want. Start the main campaign with advantage on spell attack rolls and the trait: Unpredictable (enemies cannot reliably predict your spell choices; they have Disadvantage on their first counterspell attempt per encounter).

THE BLACK ROBE

Nuitari's Will -- Power in Service of Power

The black robe is not a sentence. It is not an admission of evil. It is the most honest answer to what the Tower asked you: you want power and you will not pretend otherwise. Nuitari's moon is invisible to those without magic -- only mages can see it, and tonight it is full. You can see it clearly. It looks back. The Black Robes are feared because they are understood poorly. You have the chance to be understood better. Or not. That is entirely up to you.

Title Granted	Mage of the Black Robes, Conclave-recognised, feared, precise.
Campaign Feature	Nuitari's Hunger (1/day): When you reduce a target to 0 HP with a spell, you regain a spell slot of 1st or 2nd level. The magic returns to the source.

Your Road to Vogler:

You ride toward Vogler as something the Dragon Armies have reason to fear and the Solamnic Knights are not sure what to do with. This is precisely correct. Start the main campaign with advantage on Intimidation checks and the trait: Dark Knowledge (you know one secret about any named NPC after one hour of observation).

ROMANCE EPILOGUES -- OATH ENDINGS

Scenes 63-76 -- Read your Oath endings below.

SCENE 63 -- LYRA ASHFEN

The forest releases you and she is there -- your oldest friend, wearing robes that are a different colour or the same depending on what you both chose. She looks different. You saw it in the Hall of Emergence. She has been somewhere the Trials took her and she came back changed and she is still her. She says your name. Then: 'I thought about you in the second Trial. When I had to choose.' A pause. 'I chose the cold thing. The correct thing. I needed you to know that it was cold and that I chose it anyway.' You pull her close and she lets you -- not romantic, just: the specific embrace of two people who walked through something alone and are on the other side and are genuinely glad the other one made it. Then she steps back and looks at you with fifteen years of friendship tipping into something else -- tilts her head and says, very quietly: 'Also I have been in love with you for about four years and I thought I might as well say it now that we are out of the Tower and neither of us has to be impressive anymore.' The road to Vogler can wait half an hour. In the main campaign, Lyra is your companion, your counterpart, and the person who knows you best.

SCENE 65 -- TORVEN ASHFALL

He meets you at the forest's edge. He looks at your robe -- professional -- and then at your face, which is not professional at all. He exhales something he has been holding since the moment you walked into the trees. 'You are infuriating,' he says, which from Torven means: I was afraid for you and I am very glad you are standing here. He crosses the clearing and does not stop at arm's length the way he has been stopping at arm's length for weeks. He cups the back of your head with one hand and kisses you with the focused deliberateness of someone who has been thinking about exactly this for the better part of a month. When he steps back the coin is not appearing and disappearing -- his hands are still for the first time since you met him. 'I intend to be insufferable about this,' he says. 'Fair warning.' That night the camp is smaller than it has been. In the main campaign, Torven appears at key moments with information, support, and the particular certainty of someone who knows exactly where his loyalties lie.

SCENE 66 -- COMMANDER SERATH

They are waiting at the cart. Everyone else is managing their own reunion. Serath stands slightly apart, in the habit of someone who has learned not to assume they are included. You go to them specifically. They track you crossing the distance with the stillness of someone containing something. When you reach them they say: 'You came back.' 'Yes.' 'Both of you.' 'Yes.' A pause. 'I was not certain you would.' You were not certain either. You don't say this because they know it. They look at your robe. Something resolves in their face -- some calculation that was running for the whole time you were in the Trials. 'I have been thinking,' they say, 'about what I owe and who I owe it to. I've reached a conclusion.' They meet your eyes. 'If you'll have me -- I'm on your side. Whatever side that is.' In the main campaign, Serath is a complex and invaluable ally whose past will surface in Act 2.

SCENE 67 -- THESSALY BRIGHTWATER

She has been writing since you went in. The ink on her fingers is new and extensive. She meets you at the treeline and for once her notebook stays in her bag and her pen stays behind her ear and she is just -- looking at you. She writes one

sentence before she puts it away. You cannot see what it says. 'I came here for the story,' she says. 'I am staying for something else.' She closes the distance and takes your face in both hands -- ink-stained fingers, warm palms -- and kisses you the way she does most things: with complete attention, nothing held back, notebook closed. When she pulls away her eyes are bright and her composure is entirely gone and she looks delighted about this. 'The story is better with you in it,' she says. 'It always was.' In the main campaign, Thessaly's network provides intelligence at key moments and her writing becomes the record of what you do.

SCENE 68 -- ZINNIA QUICKFINGERS

She hits you at approximately chest height, arms around you, completely without warning, which is how Zinnia expresses most strong emotions. You catch her automatically. She does not let go for a considerable time. When she does, she holds you at arm's length with her hands on your shoulders and looks at you with complete seriousness. 'I want to tell you something,' she says. 'I am a Kender, which means I cannot be afraid. There are also things I cannot do -- I cannot lie, I cannot hold grudges, I cannot stop caring about people once I have started. I started with you on the first morning in Millhaven.' She looks at your robe. 'Whatever colour that is -- I like it. I like you. I am going to go everywhere you go until you tell me not to, and even then probably a bit further.' This, from Zinnia, is a declaration. You feel it land like one. In the main campaign, Zinnia is with you. She was always going to be with you.

SCENE 72 -- THE GUARDIAN OF THE FIFTH DOOR

They stand at the forest's edge -- as far as they can come. The trees are at their back. The ordinary world is a few feet away. They are very still. You cross to them. As close as the boundary allows. They say: 'I have been in this Tower for longer than your civilisation has existed. In that time I have remembered approximately eleven mages clearly. Not fondly -- clearly. The way you remember a moment that changes how you see everything after.' They look at you. Their eyes are the moon, full and close. 'You are the twelfth,' they say. 'I wanted you to know that before you go, because you will not be coming back for a long time and I do not know if the Tower will let me stand at this edge again. I am not sorry I broke the rules.' They cannot touch you -- the boundary is real. But they hold your gaze until you have to turn and walk toward Vogler, and you do not look back only because you cannot bear to see them standing there still. In the main campaign, the Guardian communicates through dreams at key moments. They cannot leave the Tower. They have not forgotten you.

SCENE 73 -- ELARA MOSS

She is not at the forest's edge. You did not expect her to be -- Millhaven is three days behind you. But when you reach the first waystation on the road south there is a letter, left with the innkeeper by a woman matching her description who came through two days ago. It says, in her handwriting: 'I came as far as I could. I wanted to see the road you took. I do not regret coming. I do not regret going home. I left something with the innkeeper that you will need -- your grandmother's book has a page you have not found yet. Look near the back. I found it by accident. I love you. I am going home. Find me there when you are finished.' The page is there. It is a map of something you will need in the main campaign. You read the letter twice and fold it precisely and carry it in the same place you carry everything that matters. In the main campaign, Elara can be found in Millhaven -- if Millhaven survives. That depends on choices you make in the early chapters.

SCENE 74 -- NASHA VREN

She falls into step beside you on the road south with the easy comfort of someone who has decided where they are going and who they are going with. The coin appears and disappears across her knuckles. After a while she says: 'I should tell you something about what I am like.' You wait. 'I disappear for months at a time. The Conclave sends me places. I am not always reachable and I am not always able to explain why.' The coin vanishes. 'I am telling you this so you can decide now rather than being surprised by it later.' You tell her you can manage. She: 'Good. Also -- ' She hands you the coin. It is heavier than it looks. 'Keep this. So you know I intend to come back for it.' In the main campaign, Nasha appears at unexpected moments with critical intelligence and the particular satisfaction of someone who told you she was reliable and is being proved right.

THE BRIDGE TO OUR CAMPAIGN

You are three days from Vogler. The Dragon Army is two days ahead of where anyone expected. You are a mage of the Conclave -- or Unchosen -- wearing robes you earned in blood and truth, carrying companions who chose to be here, heading toward the beginning of the main adventure.

What You Carry Forward	Details
Your Robe	Determines how NPCs react: White = trusted; Red = respected/wary; Black = feared; Unchosen = unknown.
Robe Points	Convert to Background: White = Acolyte/Sage, Red = Guild Artisan/Sage, Black = Hermit/Criminal.
Lyra Ashfen	If alive and at Flame/Oath, named companion with her own quest line in the main campaign.
Torven Ashfall	If Oath reached, appears twice in Chapters 1-3 with significant aid. Otherwise sends a letter.
Serath	Continues their arc from Book I or II. Dragon Army knowledge critical in Chapter 2.
Thessaly	Her coverage shapes how Vogler and Kalaman receive you.
Zinnia	Present. Obviously. She has your second-best spellbook and has memorised it.
The Guardian	Communicates via dreams. Once per chapter consult the Tower for lore or guidance.
NPC from Millhaven	If you wrote to them (Scene 11), a letter waits in Vogler. They are alive.
Second Chance Penalties	If you died in a Trial, your penalty persists until end of Chapter 1.

Robe Score Sheet

WHITE: ___ pts | RED: ___ pts | BLACK: ___ pts Highest score = Your Robe (or Final Trial answer overrides)

Companions present at adventure's end (circle): Lyra / Torven / Serath / Thessaly / Zinnia / Guardian

Romance Oath reached with (circle): Lyra / Torven / Serath / Thessaly / Zinnia / Guardian / None

School of Magic chosen at Scene 40: _____ Robe Colour: _____

The Towers have given you what you came for.

The Dragon Queen's armies are marching. The gods are returning. The world is about to change.

You are a mage. You are ready.